

The Vicar of Wakefield



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF OLIVER GOLDSMITH

Oliver Goldsmith was born in Ireland in 1728, where his father worked as a curate, an assistant to the parish priest. After studying at Trinity College in Dublin, Goldsmith was rejected from the Church of Ireland. He went on to travel through Europe, studying, tutoring, and simply wandering. Goldsmith then settled in London, eking out a difficult living as a Grub-street hack writer and translator. He began to grow in fame through his works *An Enquiry into the Present State of Polite Learning in Europe* and *The Citizen of the World*, the latter written by a Chinese alter ego named Lien Chi Altangi. *The Vicar of Wakefield*, published in 1766, is his only novel and most acclaimed work, but his 1773 play *She Stoops to Conquer* also brought him significant success. Goldsmith lived extravagantly and was often in debt, and he was known for his erratic temper and behavior. He died prematurely in 1774, possibly of kidney failure.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Europe in the late 18th century was in a state of constant upheaval, one that Goldsmith was especially well positioned to witness as a result of his many travels. The British Empire had rapidly expanded over the course of the century despite its involvement in numerous wars, and this together with the beginning of the Industrial Revolution lead to a total transformation of British society. Despite the explosion of economic activity and the global, cosmopolitan society of London and other large cities, the British countryside of Goldsmith's childhood continued on much as ever, providing a clear reference point to the pastoral idyll he anchors his moral philosophy to in *The Vicar of Wakefield*. In response to this state of flux, aesthetic debates of the time were heavily charged with moral and political significance, leading to vicious arguments over the merits of classicism, theater, and all other manners of "taste," many of which Goldsmith reproduces in his fiction.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

The Vicar of Wakefield is one of the preeminent examples of the sentimental novel, an 18th-century genre that focused on the emotional responses—or sentiments—of both characters and readers to their circumstances. Largely concentrated in the latter half of the 18th century, the sentimental novel was a direct reaction to the rationalism of the earlier part of the century and paved the way for both Gothicism and Romanticism. Other important sentimental novels include

Samuel Richardson's *Pamela, or Virtue Rewarded*, Goethe's *The Sorrows of Young Werther*, and Laurence Sterne's *A Sentimental Journey* and *Tristram Shandy*. *The Vicar of Wakefield*, however, much like *Tristram Shandy*, is also very much a satire of the sentimental novel and its clichés, troubling the stability of the genre and its moral universe while laying the foundations for it. This satire would come to be more fully developed in the 19th century, most notably in Jane Austen's *Sense and Sensibility*, which is far more sharply critical in its critique of sentimentalism than Goldsmith's novel.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Vicar of Wakefield
- **When Written:** 1761–1762
- **Where Written:** London
- **When Published:** 1766
- **Literary Period:** Sentimentalism
- **Genre:** Sentimental Novel, Satire, Picaresque
- **Setting:** Rural England
- **Climax:** Sir William confronts Squire Thornhill in the prison
- **Antagonist:** Squire Thornhill
- **Point of View:** First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

A Quick Buck. According to the writer Samuel Johnson, who was friends with Goldsmith, the timing of *The Vicar of Wakefield's* publication was especially lucky for the author. Johnson was called to help Goldsmith, whose landlady had had him arrested for failing to pay his rent, by selling the newly finished novel to a publisher on his behalf. Johnson quickly did so, winning Goldsmith's freedom. The veracity of this story is doubtful, however, as Goldsmith had finished the novel several years before it was published.

A Man of Fashion. Goldsmith was known for his flashy, extravagant style—he was often seen around town wearing bright, "vulgar" clothes—despite being deep in debt. Given what is known of his fragile ego and jealous nature, his contemporaries thought that Goldsmith presented himself this way to cover up his own perceived weaknesses.



PLOT SUMMARY

Dr. Primrose, a vicar in the idyllic country parish of Wakefield, chooses a steady, dependable wife, and together they raise a happy family. The Primroses' older two sons George and Moses

are gifted at scholarship and business, respectively, and their daughters Olivia and Sophia are beautiful and musically talented. They soon have two more young boys, Dick and Bill. However, a combination of circumstance and pride soon threatens the family's happiness. Dr. Primrose is unable to hold back his strong theological opinions, causing him to pit himself against Mr. Wilmot, the father of George's fiancée Arabella. Then the merchant holding the Primrose fortune runs off with the Primroses' fortune, leaving them destitute and causing Mr. Wilmot to break off the marriage.

The Primroses relocate to a parish owned by Squire Thornhill, where they will live in comparative poverty; the family sends George London to make his own way in the world. On the way to their new home, the family meets a kind stranger named Mr. Burchell, who quickly develops a mutual attraction to Sophia. Despite their hardships, the family feels welcome and happy in their new home. They soon meet the Squire, who is frivolous, materialistic, and dependent on his better-liked uncle, Sir William, for his fortune, but he is kind to the Primroses and quickly becomes close to the family. He showers attention on Olivia in particular, leading Mrs. Primrose to hope for a marriage. He also introduces the Primrose daughters to two highly cultured town ladies, but the ladies' intention to bring the daughters with them to London for the winter is foiled after someone spreads malicious, anonymous rumors spread about the family.

Fate continues to disappoint the Primroses, as both Moses and Dr. Primrose after the same man in disguise cheats them out of money they make from selling their horses. Later, the family learns that Mr. Burchell is responsible for spreading rumors about them, causing them to end their relationship with him. Mrs. Primrose continues to scheme new ways to pair off Olivia and the Squire but is unable to induce him to propose to her.

Things get even worse when Olivia elopes with an unknown man. Dr. Primrose sets off in pursuit of her, initially suspecting that the Squire is Olivia's mystery suitor. However, people along the way who saw Olivia describe an abductor resembling Mr. Burchell. Eventually, Dr. Primrose loses the trail and prepares to head home in defeat.

Along the way, a well-dressed gentleman invites Dr. Primrose to dinner, and they get into a heated argument about liberty and the monarchy. Dr. Primrose soon discovers that the supposed gentleman is only a butler in disguise after the man's master, Mr. Arnold, returns home, along with Arabella Wilmot, Mr. Arnold's niece. Dr. Primrose then accompanies them to a play, where he is shocked to find George cast in the leading role.

George then tells his father, Mr. Arnold, and Arabella of his travels. After failing as a Grub-street hack writer in London, he served none other than Squire Thornhill, fighting a duel on his behalf. While he hoped to find a career by taking the Squire's recommendation to Sir William, he was angrily rebuffed for serving the Squire in such an immoral capacity. George then

traveled across Europe, selling art, tutoring, and singing for a living before returning to England. At that very moment the Squire, who is now pursuing Miss Wilmot, arrives. He generously procures an officer's commission for George, telling Dr. Primrose he will consider it a loan. Dr. Primrose then sets off for home. Along the way, he encounters Olivia at an inn, and she reveals to him it was the Squire, not Burchell, who abducted her. Moreover, the town ladies were also a plot of his and were only sex workers in disguise; Burchell's letter, it turns out, was an attempt to protect her and Sophia from the Squire. Olivia also recounts how the Squire had a fake priest "marry" him to Olivia before promptly abandoning her. Dr. Primrose assures Olivia the family will forgive her and takes her home.

Upon Dr. Primrose and Olivia's return, the Primrose house catches fire, leaving the family destitute. The Primroses also learn that the Squire and Miss Wilmot are engaged. Soon the Squire visits them, and Dr. Primrose angrily confronts him, telling him he will never consent to the Squire marrying anyone but Olivia. The Squire retaliates by threatening to demand his loan be repaid, and two days later officers of justice come to take Dr. Primrose to the gaol. Though an angry crowd of parishioners attempts to free him, Dr. Primrose calls them off and goes to prison willingly. There he meets Jenkinson, the man who cheated him and Moses. Jenkinson is now reformed and apologetic. Dr. Primrose sets about reforming the other inmates, preaching to them and encouraging them to live morally and productively; to everyone else's surprise, his efforts eventually succeed.

Though his family and Jenkinson try to convince Dr. Primrose to submit to the Squire and give the marriage his blessing in the hope that he will be released, he refuses to do so. They also attempt to petition Sir William but receive no reply. Olivia, weak and depressed after her ordeal, dies. After Olivia's death, Dr. Primrose finally relents and asks the Squire to be released, but the Squire refuses. The Primroses then learn that unknown assailants have kidnapped Sophia. The family then receive word from George, who is happy and well, and Mrs. Primrose reveals she asked George to duel the Squire; thankfully, however, the happy tone of George's letter suggests that he never got Mrs. Primrose's message. Just then. However, George is brought to the prison, charged with wounding the men the Squire sent to fight him, confirming that he did receive his mother's letter after all.

Suddenly, Mr. Burchell enters with Sophia, who he has been rescued, though her kidnapper escaped. Burchell then strongly admonishes George for dueling and reveals himself to be Sir William. After hearing a description of Sophia's kidnapper, Jenkinson recognizes him as a criminal named Timothy Baxter and leads the officers to him. At that moment, the Squire arrives. His uncle and the Primroses confront him, and soon Jenkinson returns with Baxter, who helped the Squire abduct Olivia.

As the Squire's guilt comes to light, Miss Wilmot too enters the prison and breaks off her engagement in horror; unfortunately, the Squire has already taken possession of her fortune, but she gladly gives it up to marry George instead. It's then revealed that Olivia is in fact alive—the family only told Dr. Primrose she was dead to convince him to submit to the Squire and, hopefully, lead to his release. Moreover, Jenkinson actually brought the Squire a real priest for the supposedly fake marriage in order to blackmail the Squire, making Olivia the Squire's lawful wife.

In the end, Miss Wilmot regains her fortune, and Sir William gives Olivia the allowance he gave the Squire. At Dr. Primrose's request, the Squire isn't punished for his actions. Sir William also chooses to marry Sophia, and Dr. Primrose marries them along with George and Miss Wilmot.

Dr. Primrose then learns his original fortune has been recovered. As the family's life becomes idyllic once more, he reminds himself to remain as grateful in happiness as he was patient in suffering.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Dr. Charles Primrose – Dr. Charles Primrose is the novel's protagonist. He is a country vicar, husband, and father of six. Deeply kindhearted, he is nevertheless guilty of excessive pride, often sabotaging his family through his inflexible morals. Before the Primroses lose their fortune, Dr. Primrose donates his entire salary to the poor of Wakefield, leaving his own family destitute. He also ruins his son George's marriage to Miss Wilmot by refusing to back down in his theological argument with Mr. Wilmot. Dr. Primrose is critical of Mrs. Primrose and his daughters' quest for wealthy suitors like Squire Thornhill, deeming their efforts foolish and vain. Still, he is patient and gentle with them, playing the role of the benevolent father and refusing to resort to authoritarian methods. Dr. Primrose's pride is offset by his consistent humility, as he is willing to listen to each and every person he meets on his journey. He is equally firm in his commitment to forgiveness and redemption; he refuses to give up his daughter Olivia, despite the dishonor that her elopement with the Squire brings to the family. Indeed, the only time Dr. Primrose becomes truly angry with his wife is when she refuses to extend the same Christian principle of forgiveness. Dr. Primrose's goodwill isn't limited to his family, however; he also embarks on an ambitious project to reform the other prisoners when the Squire arrests him and places him in the goal. Though society may reject the prisoners, Dr. Primrose is convinced that they too are worthy of forgiveness and preaches to them until they begin to reform. This quest is consistent with Dr. Primrose's general belief that Christian ideals necessitate engaging in society; Ultimately, however,

despite his investment in the betterment of society, Dr. Primrose is happiest with his family, sitting around **the fireplace** drinking their famous **gooseberry wine**.

Mr. Burchell (Sir William Thornhill) – Mr. Burchell is a charitable and seemingly destitute stranger whom the Primroses meet on their way to Squire Thornhill's lands. After Burchell is unable to pay his bill at the inn because he gave away his money to prevent a dog thief from being whipped, Dr. Primrose gladly lends him money, happy to help such a generous person. Burchill soon forms a friendship with the Primroses, developing feelings for Sophia after he rescues her. He is a talented everyman who is able to discourse with Dr. Primrose on theology and philosophy, heal Dr. Primrose's wounded arm, fight off Sophia's abductors, and entertain children like Dick and Bill. He tells the Primroses about Sir William Thornhill, slipping from the third to the first person as he describes the lord's excessive generosity, which almost bankrupted him, though he does not yet reveal that he is in fact Thornhill. He continues to visit the family and protect them from his nephew the Squire's plots, foiling the town ladies' attempt to bring Olivia and Sophia with them to London. The Primroses misunderstand this as jealousy, however, and break off their relations with him. They then wrongly blame Burchell for Olivia's abduction, only learning later that the Squire was the true culprit. In the end, Burchell reveals himself to be the very same Sir William whom George appealed to in London. He then confronts the Squire and, after several witnesses are produced, ensures that justice is done, giving Olivia the Squire's allowance, donating money to the prisoners, and marrying Sophia himself.

Squire Thornhill – Squire Thornhill is the villain of *The Vicar of Wakefield*. A frivolous, disengaged landlord, the Squire leaves all the administration of his land to his steward, preferring to hunt or spend time in London instead. Despite his profligate spending and excessive womanizing, the Squire is dependent on his better-liked uncle, Sir William, for his fortune. The Squire is also a free thinker—he lives a hedonistic lifestyle, disdaining religious, moral, and sexual norms. Nevertheless, the Squire charms the Primrose family, who hope he will propose to their daughter Olivia. Though he appears to be both a serious suitor and genuine friend to the family, he is in fact scheming to betray them. The Squire brings the town ladies, who are really sex workers in disguise, to attempt to lure Olivia and Sophia to London, but his uncle, who is disguised as Mr. Burchell, thwarts his efforts. The Squire then abducts Olivia and acquires a false priest to "marry" them before abandoning her. The Squire then attempts to marry Miss Wilmot for her fortune, though he fails at this scheme as well. Petty and vindictive, the Squire has Dr. Primrose arrested for his debts. The Squire is eventually caught, however, when he sends Timothy Baxter to abduct Sophia so that he can pretend to rescue and then seduce her. Though Miss Wilmot breaks off the marriage, the Squire has

already secured her fortune through their engagement. His former servant Jenkinson, however, then reveals that the marriage to Olivia was actually legitimate—making the Squire's marriage to Miss Wilmot illegitimate and depriving him of Miss Wilmot's fortune. His scheme thwarted, the Squire goes to live with another relative and spends his days practicing the French horn; the story leaves it unclear if he will ever reform his ways.

George – George is the Primrose family's eldest son. George is a serious, honorable man with scholarly inclinations. Engaged at the start of the novel to Miss Arabella Wilmot, the engagement falls through after Dr. Primrose insults Mr. Wilmot during an argument about theology and, later, when the Primrose family loses their fortune. After the newly impoverished family is forced to move to Squire Thornhill's land, George is sent to the family's cousin in London to find a suitable career. Arriving in London, however, George struggles enormously, working as a Grub-street hack writer and a servant to Squire Thornhill, eventually fighting a duel on his behalf. While George hopes to find better work by petitioning Sir William, Sir William's disapproval of dueling leads him to angrily reject George. George then travels through Europe, singing for room and board, selling paintings, and tutoring a wealthy young British gentleman. Eventually he makes his way back to England, where he becomes an actor, playing the part of Horatio. Eventually Dr. Primrose and Miss Wilmot happen to attend one of his performance and learn of all he's been up to. Though the Squire is now courting Miss Wilmot, Miss Wilmot clearly still loves George, and the Squire procures an officer's commission to get George out of the way. George finds great success in the army but returns when Mrs. Primrose writes him and reveals the Squire's villainy, asking George to duel him. George is initially arrested for his role in the duel, but after learning of the Squire's treachery, Sir William forgives George and arranges for his release, and Miss Wilmot and George marry at last.

Olivia – Olivia is the older of the two Primrose daughters. Known for her beauty, Olivia is the more carefree and adventurous of the two, constantly seeking to please the people around her. She is musically talented and enjoys entertaining her family around **the fireplace** with her sister Sophia and her brothers Dick and Bill. Once the Primroses arrive in their new home, Olivia quickly becomes enamored with Squire Thornhill, and he chooses her as the primary target of his affections. Alongside Mrs. Primrose and her sister, Olivia attempts to stand out with fancy dresses, face washes, and other vanities, efforts for which Dr. Primrose chastises her. She hopes to get a taste of London life by working for the town ladies but is prevented from doing so by Mr. Burchell's anonymous letter. In order to force the Squire to propose to her, Olivia agrees to her mother's plan to court farmer Williams too, but she accepts her father's demand not to string him along and to marry him if the Squire does not marry her. Olivia

is then abducted while out with Dick, after which a false priest marries her to the Squire. The Squire then tires of her and attempts to force her into sex work. When she refuses, he abandons her. In despair, Olivia hides in an inn until her father finds her. Her health rapidly declines, and eventually Dr. Primrose's family tells him that she has died. However, this is only a ruse: the family merely hoped that hearing of Olivia's death would convince Dr. Primrose to submit to the Squire in the hopes of being released from gaol. Later, it's revealed that the priest who married the Squire and Olivia was a real priest, making their marriage legitimate. In response, Sir William gives Olivia the allowance he formerly gave the Squire. Olivia tells Dr. Primrose that if the Squire ever reforms, she may one day forgive him and allow him to live with her in the Thornhill manor.

Sophia – Sophia is the younger of the two Primrose daughters. Renowned for her beauty like her sister, Olivia, Sophia is the quieter and more serious of the two. Like Olivia, Sophia is musically gifted, and she often entertains her family around **the fireplace**. Sophia develops a strong attachment to Mr. Burchell early on, as they walk together during the family's journey to their new home on the Thornhill estate. While Sophia is also impressed with the Squire, she is less taken with him than her sister. She does however equally participate in what Dr. Primrose considers foolish and vain attempts to look distinguished; she, Olivia, and Mrs. Primrose all dress elaborately and use face washes. Sophia also attempts to find employment with the town ladies and is hurt and confused when she learns that Mr. Burchell was the one who foiled her chance, spreading rumors about the family with his anonymous letter. While Dr. Primrose is imprisoned, Timothy Baxter kidnaps Sophia, acting on the Squire's orders. After Mr. Burchell rescues Sophia, Dr. Primrose offers him Sophia's hand in marriage. In the end, Burchell (who is in fact Sir William in disguise) agrees to marry Sophia, bringing to fruition the fortune-teller's prediction that Sophia will marry a lord shortly after Olivia's marriage to the Squire.

Mrs. Deborah Primrose – Mrs. Primrose is the wife of Dr. Primrose and the mother of George, Moses, Olivia, Sophia, Dick, and Bill. A steady, dependable woman, Mrs. Primrose holds together the worldly affairs of the family, as her husband is preoccupied with theological arguments and moral lectures. Mrs. Primrose is renowned for her cooking and her **gooseberry wine**, and cultivates a warm, encouraging environment in their home. Despite her practicality, she is also prone to fits of fancy, foolishness, and vanity, especially in her advice to her daughters. Attempting to set Olivia and Sophia up for marriage to wealthy men, Mrs. Primrose turns to all manner of methods, from elaborate dresses to having them ride the family's workhorses to church. Mrs. Primrose's schemes, such as allowing the Squire and farmer Williams to court Olivia simultaneously, are incredibly transparent, but she is

nevertheless convinced that of their subtlety and artfulness. She displays her vanity most clearly in commission she makes of the limner, insisting on the family being painted as an incoherent collection of historical and mythical figures which, ultimately, is too large to even fit on the wall. Mrs. Primrose's frivolous, vain actions sometimes bear significant consequences, as when she breaks off the family's relations with Mr. Burchell and encourages George to attempt the duel the Squire. Ultimately, however, her good intentions make up for her occasional thoughtlessness.

Ephraim Jenkinson (A Distinguished Old Man) – Ephraim Jenkinson is a gifted criminal. He's a smooth talker who is very skilled in the art of disguise. With the help of his footman Abraham, Jenkinson convinces Moses to spend the money Moses earned from the sale of his horse, Colt, on reselling spectacles—an obviously ill-advised business venture. He also successfully scams Flamborough in the same way. Later, Jenkinson is able to cheat Dr. Primrose too, as his elaborate speeches on cosmology and praise of the vicar's theological tracts convince Dr. Primrose to let his guard down and accept a draught (a promissory note) on Flamborough instead of payment. Dr. Primrose and Jenkinson meet again in the gaol after Jenkinson's crimes have caught up with him; striving to repent, Jenkinson helps Dr. Primrose as best he can, making his cell more comfortably and attempting to convince him to submit to the Squire to expedite his release. Jenkinson plays an essential part in proving Squire Thornhill's guilt, as he confesses to having helped the Squire procure women and apprehends their former accomplice, Timothy Baxter. Even more crucially, Jenkinson reveals that he in fact obtained a genuine marriage license for the Squire and Olivia, not a fake one as they believed. While this was done for blackmail, not for charitable reasons, it prevents the Squire from seizing Miss Wilmot's fortunes and restores Olivia to honor. Sir William gifts Jenkinson a small fortune as thanks for his actions, and Dr. Primrose promises to convince Flamborough to drop the charges against Jenkinson.

Miss Arabella Wilmot – Miss Arabella Wilmot is the daughter of Mr. Wilmot. She is known for her kindness and moral goodness. At the beginning of the novel, she is George's fiancée, but Mr. Wilmot breaks off the engagement after getting into a theological argument with Dr. Primrose and after the Primrose family loses their fortune. Miss Wilmot later reencounters Dr. Primrose at her uncle Mr. Arnold's home, where the disguised butler is entertaining him. She reveals that she is still in love with George and has turned down several suitors. Together she and Dr. Primrose rediscover George among the theater company and learn the story of his travels. Miss Wilmot later becomes engaged to the Squire and, as she is ignorant of his villainy. Though the terms of their engagement give the Squire possession of her fortune, Miss Wilmot still happily breaks off the marriage to marry George instead.

Though the loss of the fortune dismays Mr. Wilmot, he consents, happy that his daughter will marry an honorable man. And when Jenkinson reveals that the Squire's marriage to Olivia was legitimate, Miss Wilmot reestablishes control of her fortune.

Moses – Moses is the Primroses' second son. A steady, dependable personality, Dr. Primrose envisions a future in business for Moses. However, Moses's business skills prove less than exceptional—Jenkinson swiftly cheats Moses out of the money he made from selling the Primroses' horse Colt. Despite his lacking business sense, Moses displays a practical attitude toward the affairs of the Primrose household, envisioning the materials benefits of a marriage between Olivia and farmer Williams such as the use of his cider press, and supporting the family singlehandedly as a day laborer when Dr. Primrose is imprisoned.

Dick – Dick is the one of the Primroses' two younger sons. The more talkative of the two, Dick illustrates Dr. Primrose's moral lectures with fables, telling the story of the giant and the dwarf to accompany his father's warning of the dangers of attempting to exceed one's station in life. Dick is present with Olivia when she is abducted but is unable to describe her kidnappers to his family. Dick almost exclusively appears alongside his brother Bill. Like Dick, Bill is very attached to Mr. Burchell, who frequently brings him gifts.

Mr. Wilmot – Mr. Wilmot is the wealthy father of Miss Arabella Wilmot, George's fiancée and eventual wife. Mr. Wilmot initially breaks off his daughter's engagement to George after learning that the Primrose family has lost their fortune, and also because he and Dr. Primrose viciously argue about their differing views on morality and monogamy. Though he is a kind and reasonable man, Mr. Wilmot is known for his excessive love of money. Sir William chastises him for this, and only after this is he induced to both donate to the prisoners and accept George's marriage to his daughter without a dowry.

The Town Ladies (Lady Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilelmina Amelia Skeggs) – The town ladies, Lady Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilelmina Amelia Skeggs, are two women of extremely distinguished appearance who come to stay with Squire Thornhill, supposedly visiting from London. The Primroses, ignorant of city life, are dazzled by the ladies, and Mrs. Primrose, Olivia, and Sophia go to great lengths to try to impress them. When the ladies reveal that they are seeking companions to work in their households in London for the winter, the Primroses ask the Squire to convince them to accept their daughters for the positions. This hire is foiled, however, after someone starts spreading scandalous (but false) rumors about the Primroses. Later, the family discovers that Mr. Burchell is responsible for spreading these rumors, but he only did so to protect the family: later, the Primroses learn that the ladies were in fact disguised sex workers whom the Squire hired to seduce (and then ruin) the Primrose daughters.

The Butler (The Well-Dressed Gentleman) – The disguised butler is Mr. Arnold's servant who presents himself to Dr. Primrose as the master of the house. After meeting Dr. Primrose in a tavern, the disguised butler insists that Dr. Primrose accompany him home. There, the men become embroiled in a heated argument about monarchy and liberty. While the butler boasts of being extremely well read, it is unclear if this is true, and he takes issue with Dr. Primrose's defense of the king and attempts to throw him out. When his disguise comes to light, however, Dr. Primrose intervenes and convinces Mr. Arnold not to fire the butler. The butler later informs Dr. Primrose of the Squire's attempts to marry Miss Wilmot.

Flamborough – Flamborough is the Primroses' neighbor. A simple, kindhearted farmer, Flamborough and his family initially provoke contempt in the Primroses, who do everything they can to one up him, such as commissioning the limner to paint an even greater, more elaborate portrait for them than he did for the Flamboroughs. Nevertheless, Flamborough consistently helps the Primroses in their hour of need, and Dr. Primrose praises him for his goodness. Like Moses and Dr. Primrose, he is cheated by Ephraim Jenkinson, who takes advantage of Flamborough's trusting nature.

Farmer Williams – Farmer Williams is a simple, kindhearted farmer who is in love with Olivia. Mrs. Primrose uses him to goad the Squire into making a proposal, hoping that the fear of competition will force the Squire to declare his love. Dr. Primrose would prefer that Olivia marry farmer Williams, who is steady and dependable, but Olivia's abduction thwarts his plans. When Olivia returns, farmer Williams renews his affections, but she is too depressed to reciprocate them.

Timothy Baxter – Timothy Baxter is a very tall, long-legged criminal with red hair and a distinctive scar over his eyebrow. He is also, according to Jenkinson, the fastest runner in England, able to outpace even Mr. Burchell. Baxter and Jenkinson worked together to procure women for Squire Thornhill. As part of his plan to seduce Sophia and betray the Primrose family, the Squire sends Baxter to Squire to kidnap Sophia so that the Squire may pretend to rescue her, but Mr. Burchell prevents this from happening. The Squire also duels George with three other men on the Squire's behalf. Baxter confesses when Jenkinson apprehends him, and in the end he goes to prison for his crimes.

The Primroses' Cousin – The Primrose's cousin in London is an unnamed, equally impoverished relative to whom George goes in search of work. The cousin, however, is unable to help George find work in a school and suggests instead that he apply himself to the Grub-street literary scene. He and George later reunite in Paris, where the cousin has become a successful art dealer.

The Young Aristocrat – The young aristocrat is George's tutee

in Paris. He's a young British gentleman who is known for his extreme stinginess. The aristocrat attempts to spend as little money as possible on their trip, and eventually abandons George in Italy so he doesn't have to pay for George's boat fare back to London.

The Prisoners – The prisoners inhabit the gaol where Dr. Primrose is imprisoned for his debts. While Dr. Primrose finds the prisoners' morals lacking, his preaching successfully reforms them. As they listen to his sermons, they submit to fines for immoral behavior and turn their hobby of carving tobacco stoppers into a productive business.

The Officers of Justice – The officers of justice are sent to take Dr. Primrose to the gaol for his debts. Though they exercise their immoral duty without question, they are kind to Dr. Primrose in his weak state and allow him to ride on their horse. They later accompany Jenkinson to arrest Timothy Baxter.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Bill – Bill is the one of the Primroses' two younger sons. A gifted singer, Bill learns to sing country songs from farmer Williams while Williams is courting Olivia. Bill almost exclusively appears alongside his brother Dick. Like Dick, Bill is very attached to Mr. Burchell, who frequently brings him gifts.

The Gaoler – The gaoler is the warden of the gaol where Dr. Primrose is imprisoned for his debts. Despite his office, the gaoler is noted for the kindness he shows Dr. Primrose, such as allowing Dick and Bill to sleep in the cell too or facilitating George's daily visits.

The Parishioners – The parishioners are the members of Dr. Primrose's congregation on Squire Thornhill's land. They are honest peasants with a simple country lifestyle. Already opposed to the Squire for his careless, hedonistic lifestyle, they attempt to prevent Dr. Primrose's arrest but desist when he chastises them for challenging the law.

The Squire's Chaplain – The Squire's chaplain is Squire Thornhill's personal priest, and a frequent member of his hunting party. The chaplain is sent by the Squire to give the Primrose family venison, and to invite them to dine with the Squire.

The Squire's Steward – The Squire's Steward handles the daily business of the Thornhill estate, demanding the rent from all of the Squire's tenants. When the Primroses are unable to pay, the steward seizes their cattle as collateral.

The Fortune-Teller – The fortune-teller is a travelling seer who, for a fee, predicts that in under a year Olivia will marry the Squire and that Sophia will marry another lord soon after. While Dr. Primrose ridicules this prediction, it ultimately comes true, albeit in a very unexpected way.

Dr. Primrose's Old Colleague – Dr. Primrose's old colleague is a fellow man of the church whom Dr. Primrose meets while

trying to sell his horse, Blackberry.

The Actor – The actor is a member of same the theater company as George. He encounters Dr. Primrose on the road. The men bond over their dislike of Elizabethan theater and go to a tavern together.

The Manager of the Theater Company – The manager is the leader of the theater company in which George plays the role of Horatio.

Mr. Arnold – Mr. Arnold is Miss Wilmot's uncle, and the real master of the house that the disguised butler claims to own.

Abraham, the Footman – Abraham is the disguised Jenkinson's footman. He helps Jenkinson cheat Flamborough, Moses, and Dr. Primrose out of their money.

The Philanthropic Bookseller – The philanthropic bookseller, a reference to the real 18th-century publisher and friend of Goldsmith's John Newbery, gives Dr. Primrose the money to pay his bill at the inn. There, he laments his unsuccessful pursuit of Olivia. He previously published Dr. Primrose's tracts arguing for monogamy.

TERMS

Vicar – In the Anglican Church, a vicar is a type of parish priest. During the period in which *The Vicar of Wakefield* is set, vicars were distinguished from other parish priests by their receiving only the "lesser" share of tithes, or taxes levied on the parish, with the "greater" share going to the local secular landlord—in Dr. Primrose's case, to **Squire Thornhill**.

Limner – While the term "limner" often describes illuminators of manuscripts, it is also a general term for an ornamental painter; it is the latter kind who paints the Primroses' portrait. Limners in the 18th century were often painters of limited means and formal training who traveled and completed works like the portrait on commission for private clients.

Jesuitism – Jesuitism is the religious practice and philosophy of the Society of Jesus, or the Jesuits, a Catholic religious order. Because of their influence, conspiracy theories about the Jesuits abounded throughout Europe. To opponents of Jesuitism, the order was synonymous with cunning, casuistry, and crafty or subtle argumentation. It is likely that **the disguised butler** has both definitions in mind when he accuses Dr. Primrose of Jesuitism for his monarchist political beliefs.

Grub-street – Grub-street is a pejorative descriptor for describe hack writers and their work of low artistic or literary value. The term is derived from the eponymous Grub Street in London, which was the center of the lowbrow literary scene, housing writers, publishers, booksellers of little means. Goldsmith himself was a Grub-street hack in the earlier part of his career, drawing on this experience among others for the stories of **George's** travels.

Officer's Commission – An officer's commission is a position of higher rank in the British army purchased with a cash bond, skipping the lower ranks entirely. The practice of purchasing commissions was in place from the 17th through 19th centuries, and while it maintained social and class homogeneity among the officers of the British army, it also stymied the ambitions of those without means. **Squire Thornhill's** seemingly generous offer of a commission purchased on loan for **George** grants him an opportunity that the Primrose family could never have provided themselves as they lack the necessary funds, a fact which will come back to haunt them when the Squire has **Dr. Primrose** imprisoned for the debt.

Gaol – Gaol is a British spelling for jail. In the 18th century, the modern distinction between jail and prison had yet to be established.

Tobacco Stopper – A tobacco stopper is an instrument used to press down tobacco in a pipe. While imprisoned, **Dr. Primrose** encourages **his fellow prisoners** to turn their hobby of carving tobacco stoppers into a business as part of his program of moral reform.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



HUMILITY IN THE FACE OF ADVERSITY

The overarching moral of *The Vicar of Wakefield*, uniting all Dr. Primrose's adventures, successes, and failures, is the importance of humility and acceptance in the face of life's challenges. Dr. Primrose's goodness stems precisely from his willingness to accept his situation and strive to make the best of it, urging his family to do the same, however unjust his suffers may seem to him. Indeed, when he makes things worse it is because of his pride, like when he breaks off George's engagement to Arabella Wilmot because he cannot prevent himself from arguing religious doctrine with Mr. Wilmot, something he has thankfully learned to let go of by the novel's conclusion.

On the other hand, Dr. Primrose's humility greatly reduces and eventually overcomes his suffering; the gaoler shows compassion to him, allowing him not only to see his family but preach to the prisoners and improve their own circumstances, precisely because Dr. Primrose's behavior inspires mercy. George, by contrast, does wrong when he challenges Squire Thornhill to a duel on his mother's behalf, even though he and his family are clearly in the right. Seeking revenge is as unchristian as it is illegal, and George's willingness to bear the

consequences of his actions plays a large part in his being forgiven. Throughout the novel Goldsmith suggests that as a person finds rewards for virtue in the afterlife, a person's patience in their life on earth reflects their merit. While Dr. Primrose has not died and gone to heaven by the novel's conclusion, his return to wealth and happiness mirrors the eternal happiness that awaits him for his honorable submission to the tests God put him through. In depicting his hero's fall from and eventual return to grace, Goldsmith argues that a good Christian—and a good citizen—should approach a world they cannot control with patience and often outright submission, trusting that heavenly and secular justice will recognize their honorable conduct.



THE POSSIBILITY OF REDEMPTION

The universal potential for redemption in each and every human being is central to the moral philosophy of Dr. Primrose, the novel, and

Goldsmith himself. While Dr. Primrose is a paragon of goodness, at worst guilty of mostly harmless instances of pride, he remains utterly faithful to the possibility of redemption for the very wicked. Though this is primarily a Christian principle, for Dr. Primrose it extends into all aspects of secular life and should govern the everyday moral behavior of individual people as well. This redemptive vision for society is most clearly on display in the prison, where Dr. Primrose, despite the naysayers in his own family, embarks on an ambitious project of reforming the prisoners by preaching to them, encouraging them to use their skills productively, and challenging them to hold each other responsible for their behavior. For Dr. Primrose, redemption is not only about the afterlife, though that is clearly on his mind; rather, he believes just as firmly that the prisoners can be redeemed in this world, too, and that they can become healthy members of society with the right amount of attention and care. Likewise, Jenkinson goes above and beyond in redeeming himself for his past, making amends to the Primroses for defrauding them and accepting responsibility for enabling Squire Thornhill, and he is justly rewarded as a result. The Squire is in fact the only major character guilty of wickedness who is not morally redeemed by the novel's conclusion, but Goldsmith deliberately leaves open the possibility that even he, too, may someday become good. Olivia, in preparing to take the Squire in if he changes his ways, is embodying the morals her father—and Goldsmith—have preached and indeed lived throughout all their challenges. Through these character arcs, Goldsmith argues that no human being is too wicked to be redeemed; a moral society must both recognize this fact and be ready to forgive even the worst of trespasses.



FAMILY AND SOCIETY

Dr. Primrose's worldview, which is often but not always a stand-in for Goldsmith's own opinions, is equally informed by his role as a father as his role as a vicar. Moreover, it is Dr. Primrose's vision of fatherhood and the way authority should be wielded in the family that structures his vision for society, a vision in which one achieves justice and equality through patience, moderation, and instruction. Indeed, the father that Dr. Primrose strives to be is not an authoritarian father at all, but rather a moral guide to his family. While he ultimately remains in charge of making decisions, Dr. Primrose listens to and respects the decisions of Mrs. Primrose and their children, striving to balance their happiness with what he thinks is right. Rather than dominating his family as a traditional patriarch, he strives to push them toward what they already enjoy or are gifted at, encouraging George to study, Moses to practice business, and Olivia and Sophia to both pursue their musical hobbies and find husbands they truly love. Despite the family's dire financial straits, Dr. Primrose heartily accepts the possibility of a marriage between Sophia and Mr. Burchell (before he is revealed to be Sir William Thornhill); indeed Dr. Primrose is the first to suggest it explicitly, showing how for all his foolishness and failures of perception he pays close attention to his daughter's needs and desires. This idea of the head of the family—in this case the father—as a benevolent teacher rather than an all-powerful ruler is mirrored in Dr. Primrose's belief in the king as an instrument of equality.

To Dr. Primrose, a good monarch is able to settle disputes and prevent exploitation amongst its citizens and provide the moral instruction they need, as he explains in his debate with the butler disguised as a liberty-loving gentleman. Such a monarch does not use force to achieve social harmony, but serves as a mediator and moral teacher, helping their subjects to find the way for themselves. For Dr. Primrose the harmonious togetherness of **the fireplace** symbolizes not only domestic happiness, but also the possibility that all of society can live in peace, too, a dream which briefly becomes reality when he leads the prisoners, society's most downcast, together in prayer. In establishing a parallel between Dr. Primrose's visions for society and the way he guides his family, the novel illustrates the positive influence of an authority figure who gently helps their subjects become the best versions of themselves rather than modifying their behavior and morality through brute force.



EQUALITY, JUSTICE, AND THE LAW

The tension between equality and justice and their expression—or lack thereof—in the law is central to *The Vicar of Wakefield*, as many of the tragedies and misadventures that befall Dr. Primrose and his family are the result of the law's failed or imperfect deliverance of those

ideals, particularly Dr. Primrose's imprisonment for his debts. While a faithful, law-abiding citizen and patriot of Britain, Dr. Primrose cannot deny the many great and small ways in which the law is skewed in favor of the rich and powerful. Nevertheless, his faith in the fundamentally good and harmonious nature of society is rooted in and consequently as strong as his belief in the fundamentally good and redeemable nature of human beings. Through Dr. Primrose's struggle with and resolution to this contradiction, Goldsmith argues that while the law may be an imperfect tool of justice, it is a necessary one, and a society can improve its sense of justice by creating laws that are more tolerant and humane rather than disciplinary.

Dr. Primrose explicitly states this belief when he is in prison and resolves to do what he can to improve the prisoners' situation morally and materially instead of stigmatizing them as irredeemably wicked. As Dr. Primrose's scheme of prayers, moral instruction, and honest work for the prisoners finds great success, effecting a noticeable improvement in their moral behavior, he muses on how undertaking such an approach on a broader social scale could reduce crime and violence—on the part of criminals and the state, in the form of the death penalty. At the same time, Dr. Primrose is a firm believer in the monarchy, too, for he finds that while all people possess the capacity to be good, it is the uneven distribution of strength and “cunning,” not wickedness, that creates inequality, as he explains to the butler. To Dr. Primrose, a king can rectify or at least reduce this equality by acting as a mediator and peacemaker, ensuring the strong do not oppress the weak. Reforming the law therefore requires the same approach as reforming the individual: humility, patience, and a firm belief in fundamental goodness.



TRAVEL, HOME, AND BELONGING

At the beginning of *The Vicar of Wakefield*, Dr. Primrose lives a contented life in a home he and his family have hardly ever been away from, a sense of belonging which they find together again only after many travels, adventures, and hardships. Drawing on Goldsmith's own life, their departures and eventual returns serve to argue that no matter how much of the world one can see and experience, true belonging is found at home—both as a sense of place and community and, perhaps more importantly, as family. Throughout the novel, the Primrose family's happiest moments—which as memories allow them to persevere through their most difficult trials—are those of sitting together around **the fireplace**, the most explicit symbol of domestic contentment. Indeed, the novel begins and ends around the fireplace, only by the conclusion both Miss Wilmot and Sir William have joined the family too. At the same time, the Primroses' much-praised **gooseberry wine** symbolizes the wider social fabric to which the Primroses belong, reflecting

the physical embodiment of the happy, pious, and hard-working rural English community that formed them. While Dr. Primrose has a great deal of adventures in his pursuit of Olivia and later imprisonment, the question of belonging is even more sharply on display in the figure of George, who is quite literally a prodigal son. Sent away to become a scholar and support his family, George finds little success or happiness in “town life.” Likewise, his travels through Europe, while greatly broadening his view of the world, more than anything strengthen his desire to return home, as he writes letters to his family telling them that what he misses most is their time together by the fireplace. For the Primroses, like Goldsmith, the wider world can teach many things, but for true happiness and purpose one must look closer to home.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



THE FIREPLACE

The fireplace in the Primrose family home symbolizes Dr. Primrose's moral vision of the family and society as mutually informative models of enlightened behavior. The fireplace is where the family gathers after dinner—a ritual Dr. Primrose and his children repeatedly name as the happiest, most peaceful part of their lives. As both the primary site of Dr. Primrose's benevolent fatherhood and the physical embodiment of familial harmony, the fireplace is key to the parallels the novel draws between the domestic and public spheres, and also to the vision of enlightenment that these models suggest.

On the other hand, Dr. Primrose is far from a traditional authoritarian and patriarchal father. He refuses to exercise absolute power over his wife or children, instead encouraging their diverse interests to help them make their best of their own talents. The fireplace often serves as the setting for this approach to fatherhood, where Dr. Primrose pairs his moral and religious instruction with Olivia and Sophia's music and with Dick and Bill's stories. This places Dr. Primrose firmly in the Enlightenment camp regarding views on the family, siding with philosophers such as John Locke who argued for the social and moral benefits of a kinder approach to fatherhood. As a symbol of the healing power of both progressive family values and democratic constitutional monarchy, the Primroses' fireplace offers a healing answer to the family's suffering.



GOOSEBERRY WINE

The Primrose family's famously excellent gooseberry wine, which they drink around **the**

fireplace on many an occasion, represents their humble peasant origins and the traditions of the countryside. Gooseberry wine, also known as “country wine,” has been produced in Britain for centuries. Because gooseberries grow naturally throughout Britain and tend to be ready to harvest before any other summer fruits, they are one of the most accessible and inexpensive ingredients for wine. The Primroses’ wine therefore symbolizes the endurance of a rural cultural identity that the family draws strength from, despite the great upheavals of modernity.

This symbol is closely linked to that of the fireplace, which represents a progressive vision of familial and social harmony. For Dr. Primrose, a happy, healthy country family must embrace both of these ideals. While the Primroses have had access to both religious and secular education, and while they’ve experienced the world in ways his parishioners could not imagine, they nevertheless choose to stay true to their humble origins. Indeed, the novel reveals characters who embody cosmopolitan town life, like Lady Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilelmina Amelia Skeggs, to be deeply corrupt. Meanwhile, the novel portrays simple country folk like farmer Williams as virtuous. Sir William, whose own travels and failures to embody moral virtue have taught him to respect the peasant life, echoes the Primrose family’s attitude. Goldsmith, in presenting the points of class and cultural friction as such, argues that perhaps people should view the traditional ways of life disappearing under modernity should be considered as valuable sources of virtue.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Mrs. Deborah Primrose

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 37

Explanation and Analysis

These are the novel’s opening lines. The passage introduces the characters of Dr. Primrose and his wife, Mrs. Primrose. Dr. Primrose, in a narrative style that is both completely credulous and, from the reader’s point of view, highly sarcastic, praises his wife for her simplicity, stability, and predictability—that is, he commends her for being plain and inoffensive, even boring. For Dr. Primrose, this is far from a negative description, comical as it may strike the reader. Rather, these traits indicate Mrs. Primrose’s dutiful, trustworthy character, which Dr. Primrose believes makes her a better fit for raising a family than a beautiful, educated, or vivacious woman would be.

As he will expound upon at great length later, Dr. Primrose feels very strongly about both social hierarchy and aesthetic taste. The former, he argues, shouldn’t be messed with, and he finds that his wife’s talents for pickling, preserving, and cookery suits their social status well. Indeed, Mrs. Primrose’s occasional attempts to maneuver her family toward wealth are one of the few points of conflict in her relationship with her husband. Dr. Primrose is skeptical of aesthetics and beauty, and he finds Mrs. Primrose’s later attempts to elevate the family’s social status vain and immoral.

☞ But it is needless to attempt describing the particular characters of young people that had seen but very little of the world. In short, a family likeness prevailed through all, and properly speaking, they had but one character, that of being all equally generous, credulous, simple, and inoffensive.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), George, Olivia, Sophia, Moses, Dick, Bill

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 40

Explanation and Analysis

Dr. Primrose gives this statement after introducing the reader to his six children. This remark illustrates a key point of tension in his—and Goldsmith’s—vision of the family. As a new kind of enlightened, benevolent father, Dr. Primrose



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Penguin Classics edition of *The Vicar of Wakefield* published in 1982.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ I was ever of opinion, that the honest man who married and brought up a large family, did more service than he who continued single, and only talked of population. From this motive, I had scarce taken orders a year before I began to think seriously of matrimony, and chose my wife as she did her wedding gown, not for a fine glossy surface, but such qualities as would wear well. To do her justice, she was a good-natured notable woman; and as for breeding, there were few country ladies who could shew more. She could read any English book without much spelling, but for pickling, preserving, and cookery, none could excel her. She prided herself also upon being an excellent contriver in house-keeping; tho’ I could never find that we grew richer with all her contrivances.

does not seek to dominate his children, dictating to them the kind of people they will grow up to be. Rather, he sees his role in the family as essentially identical to his role in the parish: as a spiritual teacher who gently guides and encourages his flock to make the right choices for themselves, only issuing direct commands and disciplining them when absolutely necessary. Thus, Dr. Primrose praises each child for their individual gifts or inclinations: George for study, Moses for business, and Olivia and Sophia for their beauty and sociability.

Yet here Dr. Primrose throws those characterizations into question, arguing that the children are all more alike than different—to one another and to him. The reader may consider to what degree Dr. Primrose, both as a father and a narrator, projects his own hopes and dreams onto his children. Perhaps George's scholarly aptitude and Moses's business sense are also largely strengths their parents project onto them, which would explain their respective failures to achieve success in those fields.

Chapter 2 Quotes

“The temporal concerns of our family were chiefly committed to my wife's management, as to the spiritual I took them entirely under my own direction. The profits of my living, which amounted to but thirty-five pounds a year, I made over to the orphans and widows of the clergy of our diocese; for having a sufficient fortune of my own, I was careless of temporalities, and felt a secret pleasure in doing my duty without reward.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Mrs. Deborah Primrose

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 40

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Dr. Primrose explains the economic arrangements that sustained his family prior to the loss of their fortune, as well as the dissolution of George's engagement to Miss Wilmot. He also explicitly describes the division of labor in their household, in which he plays the role of spiritual teacher and his wife that of everyday manager. Most significant for the development of his character, however, is Dr. Primrose's decision to donate the entirety of relatively meager salary. This decision, though simple charity on its surface, is greatly revealing of both Dr. Primrose's genuine selflessness and Christian generosity, his moral arrogance and pride, and his faith in the social

order in which he lives.

It's clear that Dr. Primrose has donated his salary for the sole purpose of doing good, given the many other instances of Dr. Primrose's generosity throughout the novel. Still, it is not a decision he makes for himself alone, but his entire family. Dr. Primrose therefore does not actually give his wife all the family's "temporal" responsibility despite his claim to the contrary. In fact, Mrs. Primrose is in charge of managing the money they have, and Dr. Primrose takes charge of giving it away, putting his sense of well-being before his family's long-term economic security. To his credit, he does this because there is no sense of risk in Wakefield at the time. Dr. Primrose has complete faith in his society, and the sudden loss of his fortune catches him completely off guard.

“Well,’ returned I, ‘if what you tell me be true, and if I am to be a beggar, it shall never make me a rascal, or induce me to disavow my principles. I’ll go this moment and inform the company of my circumstances; and as for the argument, I even here retract my former concessions in the old gentleman’s favour, nor will I allow him now to be an husband in any sense of the expression.’

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), George, Miss Arabella Wilmot, Mr. Wilmot

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 43

Explanation and Analysis

Dr. Primrose, addressing an unnamed relative, angrily dismisses the idea that he should blunt his arguments and seek reconciliation with Mr. Wilmot. The reason why he might do so would be to save George and Miss Wilmot's marriage in light of the Primrose family losing their fortune. Previously, Dr. Primrose's stubborn argument with Mr. Wilmot nearly ended the engagement. Despite this, rather than relent, Dr. Primrose chooses to double down on his position. While on the one hand this reaction shows his firm commitment to his principles, it also betrays a sense of pride that isn't entirely virtuous. Once more, Dr. Primrose chooses his own integrity (as he sees it) over his family's financial circumstances—and, in this case, over his son's happiness. Having lost his fortune and no longer able to engage with Mr. Wilmot as social equals, Dr. Primrose takes an even more hardline course, choosing to retract the points he conceded to Mr. Wilmot in their debate. As the reader will see elsewhere in the novel, an impoverished person has nothing left but his pride, and Dr. Primrose

clings to his ferociously.

Chapter 4 Quotes

☞ The place of our retreat was in a little neighbourhood, consisting of farmers, who tilled their own grounds, and were equal strangers to opulence and poverty. As they had almost all the conveniences of life within themselves, they seldom visited towns or cities in search of superfluity. Remote from the polite, they still retained the primaeval simplicity of manners, and frugal by habit, they scarce knew that temperance was a virtue. They wrought with cheerfulness on days of labour; but observed festivals as intervals of idleness and pleasure.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), The Parishioners

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 49

Explanation and Analysis

This passage offers *The Vicar of Wakefield's* most substantial description of the peasant society of the Thornhill estate. This society, comprised largely of anonymous parishioners, is decidedly more rural and less cosmopolitan than Wakefield, which is already a small, slow-paced, and simple locale compared to London or the European mainland. The simplicity of life on the Thornhill lands, however, is precisely its charm. To Dr. Primrose, this charm is not merely an admirable characteristic of that society—it's also a moral good in and of itself. The peasants are simple, unpretentious hard workers, but they're not Puritans and so allow themselves to celebrate and enjoy life, too. Dr. Primrose describes them as almost akin to the biblical Adam and Eve before original sin, being ignorant of the ways of evil in the wider, more globally connected and economically modern world. The peasants are fundamentally good and only require the refinement of a spiritual teacher like Dr. Primrose to guide them on the right path. Even during their attempted rebellion to free their vicar from the officers of justice, the peasants do wrong in an attempt to do right and so are merely misguided, not malicious. This, the novel suggests, is the source of positive cultural character in Britain, and it stands in sharp contrast to the cutthroat competition of London life and the greed of the aristocracy.

Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ As we expected our landlord the next day, my wife went to make the venison pasty; Moses sate reading, while I taught the little ones: my daughters seemed equally busy with the rest; and I observed them for a good while cooking something over the fire. I at first supposed they were assisting their mother; but little Dick informed me in a whisper, that they were making a wash for the face. Washes of all kinds I had a natural antipathy to; for I knew that instead of mending the complexion they spoiled it. I therefore approached my chair by sly degrees to the fire, and grasping the poker, as if it wanted mending, seemingly by accident, overturned the whole composition, and it was too late to begin another.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Squire Thornhill, Olivia, Sophia, Mrs. Deborah Primrose, Moses, Dick

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 58

Explanation and Analysis

This passage, which follows the introduction of Squire Thornhill but precedes his first dinner with the Primroses, both fills in and troubles the image of domestic bliss and togetherness that the family experiences around their fireplace. At first glance, this scene is exactly the kind that makes Dr. Primrose happiest: his family gathered together around the hearth, each bettering themselves with different wholesome activities. Of course, this is not quite the truth, as Dick scandalously reveals: Olivia and Sophia are not helping Mrs. Primrose cook the venison but are instead making themselves a face wash for the Squire's visit the next day. Dr. Primrose, having so recently admonished his daughters for attempting to go to church in excessively fancy dresses, is aghast—a wash is even worse. Though his claim that washes spoil the face is likely baseless, it is the vanity of the activity that offends Dr. Primrose. Out of keeping with his character, however, is the deceptive and passive-aggressive way he addresses the problem, tipping the wash into the fire and making it look like an accident. This is the only such instance of deception that Dr. Primrose commits, and it does not sit well with his character and the value he places on honesty.

Chapter 9 Quotes

☞☞ The two ladies threw my girls quite into the shade; for they would talk of nothing but high life, and high lived company; with other fashionable topics, such as pictures, taste, Shakespear, and the musical glasses. 'Tis true they once or twice mortified us sensibly by slipping out an oath; but that appeared to me as the surest symptom of their distinction, (tho' I am since informed that swearing is perfectly unfashionable.)

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Squire Thornhill, Olivia, Sophia, The Town Ladies (Lady Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilelmina Amelia Skeggs)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 70

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage Dr. Primrose describes his family's dinner with Squire Thornhill's company, including for the first time the town ladies, Lady Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilelmina Amelia Skeggs. While the novel has alluded to the Primroses' ignorance of high culture and urban life, here it places that ignorance on full display for the first time. Dr. Primrose and his daughters are utterly bewildered by the town ladies' topics of choice, knowing little of "pictures" and "taste."

Moreover, while Dr. Primrose makes his distaste for Shakespeare known, it strikes the reader that this opinion is due more to ignorance than knowledge of the theater. Shakespeare had recently come back into style in the late 18th century, when *The Vicar of Wakefield* takes place. Dr. Primrose, however, prefers the Restoration playwrights of the mid-17th century, not seeming to realize that his taste is not only just as antiquated but decidedly out of fashion. The musical glasses were an extremely popular instrument at the time, also something the Primroses can hardly have heard in Wakefield. More striking than the family's ignorance, however, is their willingness to believe that the ladies are great, tasteful individuals despite all the evidence to the contrary and despite the harm this belief does to their own self-esteem.

Chapter 11 Quotes

☞☞ It was in this manner that my eldest daughter was hemmed in, and thumped about, all blowzed, in spirits, and bawling for fair play, fair play, with a voice that might deafen a ballad singer, confusion on confusion, who should enter the room but our two great acquaintances from town, Lady Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilelmina Amelia Skeggs! Description would but beggar, therefore it is unnecessary to describe this new mortification. Death! To be seen by ladies of such high breeding in such vulgar attitudes! Nothing better could ensure from such a vulgar play of Mr Flamborough's proposing. We seemed stuck to the ground for some time, as if actually petrified with amazement.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Squire Thornhill, Olivia, Sophia, The Town Ladies (Lady Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilelmina Amelia Skeggs), Flamborough

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 77

Explanation and Analysis

This passage finds the Primroses deeply embarrassed by their class status and lack of cultural cachet when they perceive they are being judged by the town ladies, whom they ignorantly imagine to be women of great distinction. Celebrating Michaelmas at Flamborough's house, the Primroses are horrified when Lady Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilelmina Amelia Skeggs catch them mid-game, convinced the women will judge them to be uncultured and provincial for partaking in such amusements.

This incident, beyond hammering home the Primroses' insecurity, captures the particular anxiety their social aspirations cause them. Feeling themselves to be superior to the Flamboroughs, the Primroses are nevertheless aware of just how inferior they are to the town ladies. The presence of both social relations in the same room becomes a painful reminder of the disjunction between their hopes and dreams and their reality. The Primroses' awareness, however subconscious at this point in the plot, that they are not doing right by the Flamboroughs to judge them adds tension to this scene. Indeed, by trying to flatter and impress the town ladies and Squire Thornhill, the Primroses betray not only their community but also themselves and their values.

Chapter 13 Quotes

☞ Our family had now made several attempts to be fine; but some unforeseen disaster demolished each as soon as projected. I endeavoured to take the advantage of every disappointment, to improve their good sense in proportion as they were frustrated in ambition. 'You see, my children,' cried I, 'how little is to be got by attempts to impose upon the world, in coping with our betters. Such as are poor and will associate with none but the rich, are hated by those they avoid, and despised by these they follow. Unequal combinations are always disadvantageous to the weaker side: the rich having the pleasure, and the poor the inconveniences that result from them. But come, Dick, my boy, and repeat the fable that you were reading to-day, for the good of the company.'

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Squire Thornhill, Olivia, Sophia, Mrs. Deborah Primrose, Moses, Dick, The Town Ladies (Lady Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilelmina Amelia Skeggs), Flamborough

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 85

Explanation and Analysis

Dr. Primrose explains straightforwardly to his family a moral that he has already alluded to and indirectly expounded on at length: the futility and sinfulness of social climbing. The opportunity for this lecture follows Moses's disastrous journey to the fair, where he successfully sold one of the family's horses—only to be tricked into buying a worthless pair of spectacles for resale. Dr. Primrose does not blame Moses for this error, however. Instead, he lectures to teach his entire family a lesson, feeling they have grown too ambitious and vain in anticipation of sending Olivia and Sophia to London with the town ladies.

Dr. Primrose, perceiving the gulf between the culture of high society and his family, which is far more akin to simple peasants like Flamborough than to nobility, attempts to warn his wife and daughters of the dangers of social climbing. Though later events will prove his advice true, the foreshadowing is deeply ironic, as even Dr. Primrose has no idea just how right he is. For all that he doubts the wisdom of his daughters' attempts to court Squire Thornhill, he never imagines malice on the part of the wealthy and powerful—at least not until it is too late.

☞ When gone, we all regarded each other for some minutes with confusion. My wife, who knew herself to be the cause, strove to hide her concern with a forced smile, and an air of assurance, which I was willing to reprove: 'How, woman,' cried I to her, 'is it thus we treat strangers? Is it thus we return their kindness? Be assured, my dear, that these were the harshest words, and to me the most displeasing that ever escaped your lips!' – 'Why would he provoke me then,' replied she; 'but I know the motives of his advice perfectly well. He would prevent my girls from going to town, that he may have the pleasure of my youngest daughter's company here at home. But whatever happens, she shall chuse better company than such low-lived fellows as he.' – 'Low-lived, my dear, do you call him,' cried I, 'it is very possible we may mistake this man's character: for he seems upon some occasions the most finished gentleman I ever knew.'

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose, Mrs. Deborah Primrose (speaker), Mr. Burchell (Sir William Thornhill), Olivia, Sophia

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 87

Explanation and Analysis

This passage immediately follows Mr. Burchell's departure from the Primrose household after he and Mrs. Primrose argue about the wisdom of sending Olivia and Sophia to London with the town ladies for the winter. Mr. Burchell, for as yet unknown reasons, continues to advise against the journey, much to Mrs. Primrose's chagrin. Unable to understand his motivations, which are in fact only to protect her daughters, she assumes that Mr. Burchell is attempting to sabotage the journey to keep Sophia close to him, leading to her defensive, ungenerous response. Dr. Primrose then finds himself caught in a bind, as he must choose between his obligation to be welcoming to a guest and friend like Burchell and his desire for his daughters to marry well.

As much as Dr. Primrose approves of Burchell's character, at this point in the novel he finds Burchell's flirtation with Sophia annoying and even worrisome, as he wrongly believes that Burchell is even more impoverished than the Primroses. Dr. Primrose realizes deep down that prioritizing wealth over morality is wrong, as his offering of Sophia's hand to Burchell later on will show. But at this point is only able to scold his wife for violating the basic principle of hospitality and to gesture toward a fundamental precept of Christian morality: do not judge. The generous interpretation Dr. Primrose extends to Mr. Burchell's character is truer than he realizes, foreshadowing the revelation that Burchell is indeed "the most finished

gentleman" he knows: Sir William Thornhill.

Chapter 16 Quotes

☞ We desired to have something in a brighter style, and, after many debates, at length came to an unanimous resolution of being drawn together, in one large historical family piece. This would be cheaper, since one frame would serve for all, and it would be infinitely more genteel; for all families of any taste were now drawn in the same manner. As we did not immediately recollect an historical subject to hit us, we were contented each with being drawn as independent historical figures. My wife desired to be represented as Venus, and the painter was desired not to be too frugal of his diamonds in her stomacher and hair. Her two little ones were to be as Cupids by her side, while I, in my gown and band, was to present her with my books on the Whistonian controversy. Olivia would be drawn as an Amazon, sitting upon a bank of flowers, drest in green joseph, richly laced with gold, and a whip in her hand. Sophia was to be a shepherdess, with as many sheep as the painter could put in for nothing; and Moses was to be drest out with an hat and white feather.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Olivia, Sophia, Mrs. Deborah Primrose, Moses, Dick, Bill, Flamborough

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 99

Explanation and Analysis

This passage describes the painting that the Primroses commission a traveling limner to paint. It serves as a humorous indictment of their social aspirations and complete ignorance of aesthetics and taste. The hiring of the limner is provoked by the Flamboroughs having done the same, as the Primroses continue their unspoken feud with their neighbors—a feud driven entirely by the Primrose family's insecurity. The Primroses consider themselves to be above the Flamboroughs, in part but not exclusively because of their privileged access to Squire Thornhill. As a result, they cannot stand to let the Flamboroughs have any piece of high culture without having it too. Thus, the Primroses not only also commission a painting, but they also want it larger, brighter, and more thematically complex.

The Primroses quickly overplay their hand, however, and display only their ignorance in following what they believe to be the route taken by all "families of any taste." The end product is an utterly distasteful pastiche that incoherently combines both religious and mythical subjects. Mrs.

Primrose as Venus is particularly ridiculous, all the more so with her husband next to her holding up his religious tracts in favor of monogamy. The cheapness they reveal in attempting to display wealth and status undercuts their intentions even further. The excess of the painting, which comes to embody the Primroses' misguided and ill-fated attempts to find wealth and success, is later embodied by it being too large to even be hung in their humble home.

Chapter 17 Quotes

☞ 'Wife,' said I, 'do not talk thus hardly: my detestation of her guilt is as great as yours; but ever shall this house and this heart be open to a poor returning repentant sinner. The sooner she returns from her transgression, the more welcome she shall be to me. For the first time the very best may err; art may persuade, and novelty spread out its charm. The first fault is the child of simplicity; but every other the offspring of guilt. Yes, the wretched creature shall be welcome to this heart and this house, tho' stained with ten thousand vices. I will again hearken to the music of her voice, again will I hang fondly on her bosom, if I find but repentance there. My son, bring hither my bible and my staff; I will pursue her, wherever she is, and tho' I cannot save her from her shame, I may prevent the continuance of iniquity.'

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Olivia, Mrs. Deborah Primrose, Moses

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 108-109

Explanation and Analysis

Here, Dr. Primrose rebukes his wife for her disavowal of Olivia after Olivia's abduction. Mrs. Primrose claimed that she never wanted to see her daughter again, and she went to far as to say that she wished Olivia had died rather than having her and her family's virtue "contaminated." Dr. Primrose responds to this by affirming the central place of forgiveness in Christian morality, reminding his wife that one can always be redeemed by repenting for their sins. In doing so, he implicitly contrasts a social morality of purity and virtue to a truly Christian morality of redemption, urging his family to stay true to the latter. Dr. Primrose's response to his wife is also, indirectly and in part, an apology for his own behavior upon first hearing the news of Olivia's abduction, when he demanded his pistols and intended to go seek revenge. Realizing the futility and selfishness of fighting for his family's honor rather than attempt to rescue his daughter, Dr. Primrose now resolves to set out unarmed,

asking Moses to bring him only his Bible and his staff.

Chapter 19 Quotes

☞ Politics, however, was the subject on which our entertainer chiefly expatiated; for he asserted that liberty was at once his boast and his terror. After the cloth was removed, he asked me if I had seen the last Monitor, to which replying in the negative, 'What, nor the Auditor, I suppose?' cried he. 'Neither, Sir,' returned I. 'That's strange, very strange,' replied my entertainer. 'Now, I read all the politics that come out. The Daily, the Public, the Ledger, the Chronicle, the London Evening, the Whitehall Evening, the seventeen magazines, and the two reviews; and though they hate each other, I love them all. Liberty, Sir, liberty is the Briton's boast, and by all my coal mines in Cornwall, I reverence its guardians.'

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose, The Butler (The Well-Dressed Gentleman) (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 113

Explanation and Analysis

In this humorous passage, a well-dressed gentleman (whom Dr. Primrose meets in a tavern with the travelling actors) has invited Dr. Primrose to dinner and is expounding on politics. Through the man's rant, Goldsmith gives the reader a withering parody of anti-monarchist, republican businessmen and their literary and intellectual supporters. Giving Dr. Primrose an impossibly long list of journals he reads, all of which profess different political positions, the gentleman presents a ridiculous picture of a would-be well-read intellectual. Such a reader can only stand by the vaguest of values, namely liberty.

Of course, Dr. Primrose is a firm believer in liberty, too—but not to the exclusion of equality, as his host seems to be. The gentleman's favorite turn of phrase, "by all my coal mines in Cornwall," suggests that he is a man of wealth and means. In this view, then, liberty seems to mean the liberty to do business unencumbered by the rules and regulations of the king, as the next part of his speech will indicate. Though this argument is a stand-in for very real, passionate debates of the era, the later revelation that the gentleman is merely a butler in disguise adds a comic element to his rant, suggesting that the rhetoric surrounding liberty to do business comes more from fortune-chasing aspiration than true political feeling.

☞ What they may then expect, may be seen by turning our eyes to Holland, Genoa, or Venice, where the laws govern the poor, and the rich govern the law. I am then for, and would die for, monarchy, scared monarchy; for if there be any thing sacred amongst men, it must be the anointed sovereign of his people, and every diminution of his power in war, or in peace, is an infringement upon the real liberties of the subject. The sounds of liberty, patriotism, and Britons, have already done *much*, it is to be hoped that the true sons of freedom will prevent their ever doing more. I have known many of those pretended champions for liberty in my time, yet I do not remember one that was not in his heart and in his family a tyrant.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), The Butler (The Well-Dressed Gentleman)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 117

Explanation and Analysis

In a long, passionate, and very poorly received speech, Dr. Primrose offers the well-dressed gentleman—who he still does not realize is merely the butler in disguise—his rebuttal and defense of the monarchy, culminating in this passage. Having explained his theory of inequality as a social ill that stems from unavoidable natural differences between individuals, Dr. Primrose then affirms the positive role that a sovereign like the king can and must play in mediating between the unequal individuals.

To Primrose, to have general equality (or something close to it), there must be one person above the masses invested with the power to resolve conflicts between the masses and ensure the fair distribution of resources. This is both a political argument and economic one, as his choice of examples would indicate. Comparing England, a constitutional monarchy, to the republics of Holland, Genoa, and Venice, Dr. Primrose finds that the newly developing capitalist economy will be able to exploit the poor in the absence of a higher power like the king. He is no enemy of the constitution, however, and instead argues for a balance of powers between the monarchy, the wealthy, the middle class, and the poor. This suggests that Dr. Primrose ultimately believes that society can't depend on any individual, however much that individual loves liberty, not to exploit their fellow humans. This is an intriguing position for Dr. Primrose to take given his firm faith in the basic moral goodness of all people.

Chapter 20 Quotes

☞☞ My little piece would therefore come forth in the mist of periodical publication, unnoticed and unknown. The public were more importantly employed, than to observe the easy simplicity of my style, of the harmony of my periods. Sheet after sheet was thrown off to oblivion. My essays were buried among the essays upon liberty, eastern tales, and cures for the bite of a mad dog; while Philautos, Philaethes, Philelutheros, and Philanthropos, all wrote better, because they wrote faster, than I.

Related Characters: George (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 123-124

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, part of George's narration of his travels, trials, and tribulations since leaving Wakefield and his family, he describes his failed writing career as a Grub-street hack writer. Having been found unfit to work in a school as his father had hoped he would, George is advised to put his talents to work writing for Grub-street publications. A serious and dedicated young man, he approaches his writing with painstaking craftsmanship, hoping to deliver the most ingenious of "paradoxes" to the reading public. To his dismay, his writing receives no reaction whatsoever, not because of any lack of talent on George's part but because of his inability to play the game properly. George, a perfectionist, is unable to publish with the speed or topicality necessary to stay relevant, and readers quickly forget his name and his arguments in favor of those writers more capable of commanding their attention. The Greek names George cites mean Lover of Self, Lover of Truth, Lover of Freedom, and Lover of Mankind, respectively, standing in for hack writers who find success by staking their entire career on a single unsophisticated argument.

☞☞ In this manner therefore I fought my way towards England, walked along from city to city, examined mankind more nearly, and, if I may so express it, saw both sides of the picture. My remarks, however, are but few; I found that monarchy was the best government for the poor to live in, and commonwealths for the rich. I found that riches in general were in every country another name from freedom; and that no man is so fond of liberty himself as not to be desirous of subjecting the will of some individuals in society to his own.

Related Characters: George (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 132

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes near the conclusion of George's tale, as he travels back toward England after being abandoned in Italy by his employer. Much of George's travels greatly resemble Goldsmith's own experiences traveling through Europe as a young man, both in the journey itself and the political conclusions George draws from it. George, having experienced both wealth and poverty in England, Holland, France, and Italy (and possibly elsewhere, too) compares the respective systems of government and finds monarchy to deliver the most equal, even-handed society. Here, he echoes his father in his earlier debate with the disguised butler, arguing a nearly identical point. George asserts that monarchies are capable of mediating class conflict and protecting the poor from exploitation. Meanwhile, the wealthy inevitably capture republics, remaking the law in order to abet their exploitation of the poor. Interestingly, George's conclusion comes after a tale of extreme poverty and misery in London, with very little help forthcoming from the wealthy aristocrats with whom he is acquainted. Meanwhile, in Europe, he received constant hospitality from peasants and scholars alike.

Chapter 22 Quotes

☞☞ The kindness of heaven is promised to the penitent, and let ours be directed by the example. Heaven, we are assured, is much more pleased to view a repentant sinner, than ninety nine persons who have supported a course of undeviating rectitude. And this is right; for that single effort by which we stop short in the down-hill path to perdition, is itself a greater exertion of virtue, than an hundred acts of justice.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Olivia, Mrs. Deborah Primrose

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 143

Explanation and Analysis

Dr. Primrose delivers this speech to his wife after he brings Olivia back home and Mrs. Primrose gives her a cold if not hostile reception. Reinforcing his earlier lectures of repentance, redemption, and forgiveness, Dr. Primrose now

forcefully insists that his wife offer her daughter the Christian forgiveness that he believes is their duty to extend to her. Dr. Primrose argues that although living virtuously is praiseworthy, returning to virtue after falling into sin is a far greater effort than simply avoiding sin and indicates the depth of a person's love for God and desire for redemption. Moreover, in light of his previous lecture to Mrs. Primrose before setting out to find Olivia, in which he argued that the first sin is often due to "simplicity" rather than guilt, Olivia's efforts to return to virtue after being deceived and led into sin could be seen as heroic. Dr. Primrose's rescuing of his fallen daughter both foreshadows and likely predisposes him to his next major project of redemption: reforming the prisoners, as Olivia sets an example of successfully returning to virtue against all odds.

Chapter 25 Quotes

☞☞ 'What! my friends,' cried I, 'and this is the way you love me! Is this the manner you obey the instructions I have given you from the pulpit! Thus to fly in the face of justice, and bring down ruin on yourselves and me! Which is your ringleader? Shew me the man that has thus seduced you. As sure as he lives he shall feel my resentment. Alas! my dear deluded flock, return back to the duty you owe to God, to your country, and to me. I shall yet perhaps one day see you in greater felicity here, and contribute to make your lives more happy. But let it at least be my comfort when I pen my fold for immortality, that not one here shall be wanting.'

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Squire Thornhill, The Officers of Justice, The Parishioners

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 152-153

Explanation and Analysis

In this speech, Dr. Primrose firmly chastises his parishioners for their misguided attempt to free him from the officers of justice. In doing so, he clarifies his opinion of the law, true justice, and the divergence between the two. Dr. Primrose, while aware of the injustice of the crime for which the Squire is having him arrested—unpaid debt on a loan which was offered as a gift, collected after Dr. Primrose's house burned down—he also knows that the letter of the law is on the Squire's side. Legally, he is guilty, even if morally he knows himself to be in the right. Therefore, while the law is being instrumentalized against him, Dr. Primrose believes that the officers of justice are morally correct in carrying out their duty and arresting him. Moreover, they are

extending what kindness they can to him and his family, letting him ride their horse and proceeding at a slow, comfortable pace.

Dr. Primrose does not only wish to avoid bloodshed between his parishioners and the officers, however. His duty as an Anglican priest is twofold: to the king and to the afterlife. The former will not allow him to sanction any kind of rebellion against the law, however unjust this particular law may be, and the latter will not allow to let his parishioners jeopardize their own standing through such a rebellion.

Chapter 27 Quotes

☞☞ It were to be wished then that power, instead of contriving new laws to punish vice, instead of drawing hard the cords of society till a convulsion come to burst them, instead of cutting away wretches as useless, before we have tried their utility, instead of converting correction into vengeance, it were to be wished that we tried the restrictive arts of government, and made law the protector, but not the tyrant of the people. We should then find that creatures, whose souls are held as dross, only wanted the hand of a refiner; we should then find that wretches, now stuck up for long tortures, lest luxury should feel a momentary pang, might, if properly treated, serve to sinew the state in times of danger; that, as their faces are like ours, their hearts are so too; that few minds are so base as that perseverance cannot amend; that a man may see his last crime without dying for it; and that very little blood will serve to cement our security.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), The Prisoners

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 163-164

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Dr. Primrose—who is imprisoned in the gaol—reflects on the nature of the law, justice, and reformation. He attempts his reform of the prisoners, a project that his family and friends regard as foolhardy until it begins to find success. Acting here as a conduit for the author, Goldsmith, Dr. Primrose engages directly with a prominent 18th-century debate on the nature and purpose of prisons and how one can morally justify them. Dr. Primrose finds that, at least in Britain, the law is not designed or wielded to *reform* criminals but simply to punish them.

Dr. Primrose condemns this decision not only because it is unchristian and morally compromising, but also because it is counterproductive. Dr. Primrose firmly believes that the great majority of (if not all) criminals can be reformed, just as all sinners are capable of repentance. As such, it is society's responsibility to attempt that reform. Adding to this sad state of affairs is the horror of the death penalty, which at this time society often uses as punishment for non-capital crimes. Dr. Primrose distinguishes between natural law and the law of property and finds the idea of the state executing a criminal for violating the latter to be not only loathsome but also an indictment of society. Moreover, he finds the current ineffective because it turns petty crooks into hardened criminals for life. He argues that both problems—that of crime and that of society's moral complicity in cruelty—can be solved together if society dedicates itself to reform rather than punishment.

Chapter 28 Quotes

☝ I have called off my imagination a few moments from the pleasures that surround me, to fix it upon objects that are still more pleasing, the dear little fire-side at home. My fancy draws that harmless groupe as listening to every line of this with great composure. I view those faces with delight which never felt the deforming hand of ambition or distress! But whatever your happiness may be at home, I am sure it will be some addition to it, to hear that I am perfectly pleased with my situation, and in every way happy here.

Related Characters: George (speaker), Dr. Charles Primrose, Olivia, Sophia, Mrs. Deborah Primrose, Moses, Dick, Bill

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 170

Explanation and Analysis

This passage is an excerpt from the letter George sends to his family. The Primroses read the letter together in gaol after the death of Olivia and abduction of Sophia. The letter contains one of *The Vicar of Wakefield's* most powerful images of the Primrose home, distilling the power of the fireplace and the domestic safety, comfort, and happiness it represents. George, for whom Squire Thornhill procured a position as an officer in the army, has embarked on his travels once more, albeit in a much more distinguished manner. Nevertheless, despite the sharp contrast between

his present circumstances and his previous journey as a vagabond throughout Europe, it is the same image of his family's fireplace which sustains and motivates him. Here, George reveals just how much he is his father's son, expressing the very same domestic ideal as Dr. Primrose. Of course, George's description of that ideal here is underwritten with dark irony. The Primroses read the letter with anything but great composure and have known a great deal of both ambition and distress since they last saw George. George, moreover, is no longer happy in the army, having received his mother's letter and set off to duel Squire Thornhill, as will be revealed shortly.

Chapter 29 Quotes

☝ Thus philosophy is weak; but religion comforts in an higher strain. Man is here, it tells us, fitting up his mind and preparing it for another abode. When the good man leaves the body and is all a glorious mind, he will find he has been making himself a heaven of happiness here, while the wretch that has been maimed and contaminated by his vices, shrinks from his body with terror, and finds that he has anticipated the vengeance of heaven. To religion then we must hold in every circumstance of life for our truest comfort; for if already we are happy, it is a pleasure to think that we can make that happiness unending, and if we are miserable, it is very consoling to think that there is a place of rest. Thus to the fortunate religion holds out a continuance of bliss, to the wretched a change from pain.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Squire Thornhill, George, Olivia, Sophia, Mrs. Deborah Primrose, Moses, Dick, Bill, The Prisoners

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 173-174

Explanation and Analysis

Dr. Primrose's sermon, delivered to the prisoners and his family, takes up the entirety of this chapter. Dr. Primrose is at his lowest point, having learned of Olivia's death, Sophia's kidnapping by unknown assailants, and George's imprisonment and wounding. George will be prosecuted for attempting to duel the Squire, and even Dr. Primrose's submission to the Squire has brought him nothing but further humiliation. Despite the circumstances, however, Dr. Primrose refuses to lose hope and rouses the prisoners with this speech in which he urges them to focus on the heaven to come.

In this particular section of his speech, Dr. Primrose

addresses the question of suffering, to which he has found all philosophical answers unsatisfactory. To Dr. Primrose, only religion can address the mystery of suffering. At many points throughout the novel, Dr. Primrose's character resembles the biblical Job, who maintains his faith in God despite his suffering. Unlike Job, however, and very much in keeping with the spirit of the 18th century, here Dr. Primrose offers a rationalist defense of that faith, using logic to prove religion's capacity to offer respite where philosophy cannot.

☞ Then let us take comfort now, for we shall soon be at our journey's end; we shall soon lay down the heavy burthen laid by heaven upon us, and though death, the only friend of the wretched, for a little while mocks the weary traveller with the view, and like his horizon, still flies before him; yet the time will certainly and shortly come, when we shall cease from our toil; when the luxurious great ones of the world shall no more tread us to the earth; when we shall think with pleasure on our sufferings below; when we shall be surrounded with all our friends, or such as deserved our friendship; when our bliss shall be unutterable, and still, to crown all, unending.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), George, Sophia, Mrs. Deborah Primrose, Moses, Dick, Bill, The Prisoners

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 176

Explanation and Analysis

This passage, which concludes Dr. Primrose's sermon to the prisoners, is one of his most emotionally rousing utterances, reaching a pitch that the measured vicar rarely even approaches. While earlier in the sermon he sought to prove the benefits of religion—and faith in salvation in particular—for those who are suffering on Earth, here he changes tack and dazzles his audience with a stunning image of the rapture to come. Dr. Primrose reaches his highest moral ideal in this moment, forgiving all the cruelty he has been subjected to in favor of a shared salvation, which he extends to those whom he considers the very lowliest of people: his fellow prisoners. Dr. Primrose's sense of charity, which is so broad as to often be foolish and even damaging to his own family's economic prospects, here becomes a universal ideal that can truly encompass everyone. In this sermon, Dr. Primrose makes the leap from simply being unworldly to being godly.

Chapter 31 Quotes

☞ 'I must confess, Sir,' cried he, 'that your present disappointment does not entirely displease me. Your immoderate passion for wealth is now justly punished. But tho' the young lady cannot be rich, she has still a competence sufficient to give content. Here you see an honest young soldier, who is willing to take her without fortune; they have long loved each other, and for the friendship I bear his father, my interest shall not be wanting in his promotion. Leave then that ambition which disappoints you, and for once admit that happiness which courts your acceptance.'

Related Characters: Mr. Burchell (Sir William Thornhill) (speaker), Dr. Charles Primrose, Squire Thornhill, George, Miss Arabella Wilmot, Mr. Wilmot

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 191

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Mr. Wilmot is upset because he's learned that Squire Thornhill has contractually seized possession of his daughter's fortune despite the engagement being broken off. Mr. Burchell—who has now revealed himself as Sir William Thornhill—rebukes Mr. Wilmot for greed. Once his identity has been made clear, Sir William becomes not only the arbiter of justice for the Primroses but almost justice incarnate, as he is able to combine the power of the law with the Christian generosity and goodness that Dr. Primrose believes in.

Sir William Thornhill's rebuke of Mr. Wilmot is a gentle one, as most know Mr. Wilmot to be a basically good man—one who, like everyone else, has his own vices (greed, in his case). Mr. Wilmot is not so greedy as to wish for his daughter to marry a villain like Squire Thornhill, but he nevertheless requires the gentle prodding of Sir William to remember that his daughter's happiness and the genuine love she and George feel for each other is worth far more than any fortune could be. Thus, Sir William's advice to Mr. Wilmot is, like many other such moments in the novel, a general exhortation to the reader too, urging them to accept simple happiness where it finds them rather than pursue material ends.

☞ After supper, as my spirits were exhausted by the alternations of pleasure and pain which they had sustained during the day, I asked permission to withdraw, and leaving the company in the midst of their mirth, as soon as I found myself alone, I poured out my heart in gratitude to the giver of joy as well as of sorrow, and then slept undisturbed till morning.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Squire Thornhill, George , Olivia, Sophia

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 196

Explanation and Analysis

At this point in the book, the Squire's villainy has been exposed, Olivia has been restored to honor, and George and Sophia have both become engaged once more. As such, Dr. Primrose is finally able to rest after his ordeal in the gaol. Alone in his room, Dr. Primrose prays and thanks God for his deliverance, his faith having been vindicated after all. Of course, the nature of Dr. Primrose's faith suggests that even if he weren't vindicated, he still wouldn't forsake his religion. Most striking in this passage, though, is Dr. Primrose's sound sleep, not for how it differs from his experience as a prisoner but for its consistency. On multiple occasions in the gaol, including his very first night of imprisonment, Dr. Primrose stressed his sound, easy sleep, untroubled by his own misery or the misery around him. Dr. Primrose has, quite literally, the "sleep of the righteous." Knowing that he has kept faith and lived morally, extending charity and forgiveness to all, he accepts his fate calmly, whether God will deliver him or not.

Chapter 32 Quotes

☞☞ As soon as dinner was over, according to my old custom, I requested that the table might be taken away, to have the pleasure of seeing all my family assembled once more by a cheerful fire-side. My two little ones sat upon each knee, the rest of the company by their partners. I had nothing now on this side of the grave to wish for, all my cares were over, my pleasure was unspeakable. It now only remained that my gratitude in good fortune should exceed my former submission in adversity.

Related Characters: Dr. Charles Primrose (speaker), Mr. Burchell (Sir William Thornhill), George , Olivia, Sophia, Mrs. Deborah Primrose, Miss Arabella Wilmot, Moses, Dick, Bill, Flamborough

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 199

Explanation and Analysis

In this final passage of the novel, the Primrose family finally comes full circle, having been restored to wealth, happiness, and togetherness. The family has even grown by several members, with more potential additions alluded to in Moses's courtship of Flamborough's daughter. Dr. Primrose takes this opportunity to concentrate on the simplest but most meaningful of pleasures. He gathers his family around the fireplace as they used to do in Wakefield, before their "fall," as well as on the Thornhill estate during their trials and tribulations. Dr. Primrose believes that he and his family have only reaped these rewards because of his own constant faith throughout his suffering, much like the figure of Job in the Bible. He knows, therefore, that his responsibility is not over but has merely changed. Now, he owes God faith and love for having relieved his suffering, just as he believed he owed God confidence while the suffering was still taking place. As the final line suggests, the basis of a Christian worldview is faith in and thankfulness to God.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

Dr. Primrose believes it to be a man's duty to marry and raise a family, and quickly after becoming a vicar finds himself a wife. He chooses Mrs. Primrose for her reliability rather than more exciting qualities, but their relationship is happy and stable. The Primroses live in a comfortable house in the country and spend their time visiting and entertaining neighbors and travelers; they are renowned for their **gooseberry wine**. While they are the victims of petty pranks, the most these incidents do is annoy them.

Dr. Primrose sees being a husband and father as just as essential a part of his societal role as his religious leadership position. Consequently, marrying and having children is a responsibility as much as a choice, and one which a parent should perform prudently and methodically. While Dr. Primrose's description of his wife appears sarcastic and mocking, it is clear that he is genuinely fond of her, too, and that together they have been able to establish a domestic, pastoral ideal in Wakefield.



Dr. Primrose's children—his sons George, Moses, Dick, and Bill, and his daughters Olivia and Sophia—are his pride and joy and the source of many compliments. Olivia and Sophia are polar opposites—while Olivia is excitable and striving to please, Sophia is serious. Dr. Primrose envisions a scholarly life for George and a career in business to Moses. The entire family, however, all share Primrose's meek character.

Dr. Primrose's description of his children establishes their characters and further illuminates his worldview and approach to parenting. To Dr. Primrose, his children are unique individuals with their own personal talents and flaws, but they are also unformed personalities who will be definitively shaped by the instruction they receive.



CHAPTER 2

Dr. Primrose, unconcerned with worldly affairs, donates his salary to the needy and subsists off an inherited fortune, focusing on his preaching. He has strong views on marriage, taking a strict stance against priests remarrying after the deaths of their wives. Dr. Primrose even writes an epitaph for his wife in advance. Influenced by his father's words, George courts the daughter of another priest, Miss Arabella Wilmot. The Wilmots receive the courtship well, as the Primroses can afford a generous dowry. The families carouse together, Olivia and Sophia giving concerts. Dr. Primrose, however, cannot help himself and shows Mr. Wilmot his tract on monogamy, not realizing Wilmot hopes to remarry himself. Both of them refuse to back down, and then Dr. Primrose learns that the merchant who was holding his fortune has stolen it from him. Despite this, he sticks to his pride, and soon Mr. Wilmot decides to break the marriage off.

Dr. Primrose, though he prides himself on his humility, is often a victim of that very pride—as is, by extension, his family. In his striving to live up to a religious ideal, he neglects to take concrete steps to benefit his family, putting “goodness” before “worldliness” or “practicality.” His rigid views of remarriage reflect this, as they are inapplicable to his own marriage, which he has had comically written in stone on his wife's premade gravestone. While his well-intentioned moral rigidity is harmless within the Primrose family, by provoking a fight with Mr. Wilmot, Dr. Primrose inadvertently spoils his own son's marriage, a faux pas to which he seems to hardly give any thought. On the other hand, Dr. Primrose's stoical response to the loss of his fortune casts his firm morals in a better light, showing that if he is excessively moralistic at times, he is at the very least consistent.



CHAPTER 3

While Dr. Primrose is unfazed by the loss of his fortune, he realizes this will make life much more difficult for his family. He is offered another, worse-paying job in another district, which he accepts in order to preach his strictly monogamist views freely. He then pays off the family's debt, leaving them with only four hundred of fourteen thousand pounds. Dr. Primrose urges his family to humbly accept their newfound poverty. George is sent to London to find work as a scholar and help support the family, and Dr. Primrose is confident that he will behave honorably, whether he finds success or not.

The rest of the Primrose family departs for their new home a few days later, a longer journey than any of them have undertaken before. Stopping at an inn after the first day of traveling, Dr. Primrose invites the landlord to join them at their table, where he tells the Primroses about their future landlord, Squire Thornhill. Squire Thornhill is known as a pleasure-seeker, particularly in regard to women, none of whom can resist his charms. While this perturbs Dr. Primrose, Mrs. Primrose, Olivia, and Sophia are excited by the challenge to their virtue, which they remain completely confident in. The landlord's wife then enters and informs them that another guest is unable to pay, despite having publicly spent three guineas to save an accused dog-thief from being whipped the previous day. Dr. Primrose asks to be introduced to this charitable stranger.

Dr. Primrose goes to the stranger's room and offers to pay for it, which the stranger gladly accepts but insists on repaying at a future date. Dr. Primrose shares his future address and finds they are traveling the same way. The next morning the stranger, Mr. Burchell, joins the Primroses on their journey. He and Dr. Primrose debate philosophy, and Burchell points out the various aristocratic estates along the way, including Squire Thornhill. Burchell reveals, however, that the Squire's fortune is entirely dependent on the generosity of his uncle, Sir William Thornhill. William Thornhill is renowned for his excessive generosity, which almost bankrupted him, leading him to travel Europe alone to find himself and regain his fortune. Just then, Sophia falling into a stream, interrupting Burchell's story. Burchell leaps in to save her, making a charming impression. After crossing the river, Burchell and the Primroses part ways.

Dr. Primrose is far from ignorant of the practical consequences of putting his own morals above all else, but he does so anyway, as he believes moral conduct in preparation for the afterlife is more important than any material advantage in this life. This scrupulous sense of right is further evidenced in his insistence on paying off the family's last debts before leaving Wakefield, and by his faith in George's honor rather than success.



The introduction of Squire Thornhill here foreshadows the Squire's future role in the Primroses' story, one which the family deeply misgauges from the very beginning. Mrs. Primrose and her daughters, little experienced with the world, see an attempt on their virtue as a kind of game, not realizing that the only potential losers are themselves, not the men who would make such an attempt. The charitable stranger gives Dr. Primrose a rare opportunity to meet someone who shares his notion of charity.



Though Dr. Primrose is an unworldly man, his perceptive reading of Mr. Burchell suggests that he is not as ignorant as he sometimes appears, as he finds Burchell's philosophical ideas somewhat incongruent with his impoverished appearance. Despite this, Dr. Primrose's inclination to be trusting is stronger than his power of reasoning, and he takes Burchell at face value. Burchell's explanation of the source of the Squire's wealth further hints at the Squire's character and behavior, deepening the aristocratic intrigue—a topic above and beyond the Primroses' interest or understanding. Burchell's rescuing of Sophia, however, unmistakably marks the beginning of a romance between the two.



CHAPTER 4

The Primroses' new home is a small country neighborhood neither rich nor poor, where the peasants are pious and hard-working—but also prone to festivals. The neighborhood holds a feast for their arrival and provides the family with a small and cozy if unpretentious farmhouse. Every morning, the family rises, and Dr. Primrose leads them in prayer. After that, they go about their business. In the evening, they gather around **the fireplace** together, often with guests like their neighbor Flamborough. The Primroses sing and share their famous **gooseberry wine**. The first Sunday in their new home scandalizes Dr. Primrose, as he finds Mrs. Primrose, Sophia, and Olivia elaborately dressed and made up. He chastises them for their vanity, and from then onward they revert to more plain and simple clothing.

While the novel has not described the Primroses' home at Wakefield at length, the reader can assume that there the Primroses lived in wealthier, more cosmopolitan conditions than they do on the Thornhill estate. Nevertheless, there is a simple comfort to the peasant lifestyle and, to Dr. Primrose, a deep foundation of basic moral goodness. Ultimately being of unambitious rural origins themselves, the Primroses quickly settle into their new home. Indeed, the most jarring elements of their adjustment, to Dr. Primrose, are not caused by their peasant neighbors and parishioners, but by Mrs. Primrose and her daughters' attempts to distinguish themselves from their neighbors through fancy dress.



CHAPTER 5

Near the Primroses' home is a small seat under hawthorn and honeysuckle trees looking out over the country, where they often sit, eat, read, or play music together. As autumn arrives, they settle into a comfortable routine. One day, a hunting party crosses their path. Leading it is Squire Thornhill, who initially declines to introduce himself to anyone but Olivia and Sophia; when they do not accept his overture, he introduces himself to the whole family. Squire Thornhill asks the ladies to play him a song, and while Dr. Primrose hints at them to refuse, Mrs. Primrose encourages them to play. The Squire then plays a song himself, badly, but Olivia is charmed.

Closely connected to the pastoral idyll of the Primroses' new home and community is the beauty of nature; the community's harmony with nature matches the social harmony of the Primroses' new rural community. This is a sharp contrast to the chaos and disorder of urban life, as later developments in the novel will show. Of course, the Squire's cruel pastime of hunting interrupts this harmonious existence, which is described by Dr. Primrose with disgust. Nevertheless, the Squire makes a charming first impression, perhaps not despite but because of the scandalous rumors the Primroses have heard about him and his behavior.



The Primroses invite Squire Thornhill to taste their **gooseberry wine**, and he promises to return for future visits. Mrs. Primrose schemes for a match between Olivia and the Squire; she does not see why other women's daughters should marry into wealth while her own have not. Dr. Primrose does not approve, but he sees no reason to worry, trusting Olivia to make her own judgment after he has warned him. But a gift the Squire sends them—a piece of venison from his hunt—overshadows Dr. Primrose's warnings.

Just as Squire Thornhill's high life charms the Primroses, the family's simple ways charms the Squire—or perhaps its mostly the simple beauty of Sophia and Olivia that charms him. Mrs. Primrose's practical scheming, alluded to earlier, is now on full display for the first time as she matches her husband's unconcern for worldly matters with a crude, artless attempt to elevate her family's position in society. Dr. Primrose, however, must ignore the disconcerting aspects of both the Squire and his family's behavior because he cannot bring himself to doubt his children, as that would be doubting his own parenting.



CHAPTER 6

Debating how to prepare the venison, the Primroses are pleasantly surprised by the arrival of Mr. Burchell. Burchell has a reputation in the neighbor as a poor gentleman who was known for doing ill in his youth but has since reformed. Burchell joins them for dinner—and, of course, **gooseberry wine**—and stays until very late. The youngest children, Dick and Bill, generously offer him their bed, greatly pleasing Dr. Primrose with their generosity. The next morning Burchell repays the favor, helping the Primroses with farm work, and they notice the attention—and affection—he shows Sophia as they work.

The novel further develops the sharp contrast between Mr. Burchell and the Squire, both through Burchell's reputation in the community and the different behavior he and the Squire display with the Primrose family. While the Squire patronizes the Primroses, pretending to appreciate the entirety of their simple moral lifestyle in order to be around Olivia and Sophia, Burchell genuinely enjoys the entire family's company. Moreover, Burchell grants the Primroses an important opportunity to do good, showing how different the moral economy of charity and sharing is from the social world of flattery that the Squire inhabits.



Dr. Primrose speculates on Burchell's irresponsible past, and Sophia rebukes him for his judgment. Moses agrees, and though Dr. Primrose observes Sophia's feelings for Burchell with disapproval, he decides to remain silent. As Mrs. Primrose prepares more venison for Squire Thornhill's visit the next day, Dick reveals to Dr. Primrose that his daughters are also busy preparing a face wash for the same visit. Opposed on principle to washes, which he considers vain, Dr. Primrose "accidentally" tips it over into **the fire** and ruins it.

Though he is his family's moral teacher, Dr. Primrose is not infallible, and he's grateful for their willingness to hold him to his own standards when he cannot help himself from judging others unfairly. His criticisms of Mr. Burchell reveal a constant tension in his worldview between the positive moral value of unworldly goodness and the importance of a practical, responsible approach to life. Luckily for Dr. Primrose, he does not have to grapple with the contradiction for long, as he is able to focus on the obvious moral failing of his daughters' vanity. Despite the importance he places on honesty, his destruction of the face wash show that he too is capable of treacherous acts of subterfuge.



CHAPTER 7

The Primroses go to great lengths to entertain Squire Thornhill, who brings a large party of his chaplain, his friends, and his servants. Mrs. Primrose insists on entertaining them, though the family can hardly afford to do so. The Primroses are less than enthusiastic, as the night before Mr. Burchell implied he would be marrying Miss Wilmot; trying to cheer them up, Squire Thornhill mocks her, calling her ugly. The Squire then affirms his preference for worldly pleasures over religion. He and Moses then get into an elaborate but largely empty argument full of big words and circular logic. Olivia is charmed, nevertheless.

The gulf between the Primroses' lifestyle and the Squire's is further emphasized by the contrast between their family and his large party of retainers, which plays the role of a cheap surrogate family that is tied together by wealth rather than love. The Squire's ridiculous debate with Moses cements this contrast. Though the Squire says practically nothing meaningful whatsoever, he is able to fluster and outwit Moses with his social charms.



After the Squire leaves the family argues about his character. Mrs. Primrose makes clear her intention to pair the Squire and Olivia. Dr. Primrose does not approve of such a free thinker, but his family find his judgment too harsh, pointing out they know many free thinkers who are good men.

The difficulties of engaging with the world through Dr. Primrose's strict moralistic vision are on full display here, as his family turns his own doctrine of forgiveness against him even though, as the reader will see, he is ultimately correct to judge Squire Thornhill.



CHAPTER 8

Mr. Burchell returns the next day; now, however, he begins to annoy Dr. Primrose, especially in his behavior toward Sophia. Sophia and Moses argue about poetry and aesthetic taste, comparing Gay, Pope, and Ovid, and Burchell takes issue with both of their examples, instead presenting a ballad of his own. In Burchell's ballad, a hermit learns of a young man named Edwin's spurned love, Angelina, and eventually reunites the two.

Despite his attempts to live morally, even Dr. Primrose's hospitality has limits, and he begins to find them tested by Mr. Burchell. Though Burchell has not in fact done anything wrong, the discussion on all sides of marrying off the Primrose daughters inclines Dr. Primrose to paranoia, and he begins to see Burchell as a threat. Burchell's ballad and strong opinions on art continue to suggest that there are hidden dimensions to his character of which the Primroses are not aware.



The family's conversation is interrupted by a gunshot nearby—the Squire is hunting again—and Sophia throws herself into Burchell's arms in fright. The Squire's chaplain gives Sophia his catch, which she accepts at Mrs. Primrose's urging. The chaplain tells them the Squire intends to host a ball for them that evening. He also asks to dance with Sophia, who refuses in favor of Burchell; Burchell, however, resolves to depart that evening instead, confounding Dr. Primrose.

As Burchell's romance with Sophia continues to develop, so too does Dr. and Mrs. Primrose's suspicious attitude toward him. As much as he would refuse to admit it, in part this is because Dr. Primrose has also been taken in by the dream of his daughters marrying well, and he sees Burchell as a threat to that dream.



CHAPTER 9

Returning home, the Primroses find the Squire is already there, along with two elaborately dressed young women. Soon, the ball soon kicks off; Thornhill and Olivia lead the dancing. Afterward, eating dinner, the two ladies impress the Primrose daughters with their talk of city life, discussing painting, Shakespeare, and musical glasses. The ladies suggest that Olivia spend a winter in town, which Mrs. Primrose strongly approves of. Dr. Primrose believes that becoming more cultured would be ridiculous given his family's poverty. The Squire replies that he would give Olivia half of his fortune, implying that she should reward him with sexual favors in return. Dr. Primrose loudly objects, and the Squire assures him he has no such plan in mind. The party then discusses virtue more generally, and Dr. Primrose leads them in prayers. After dinner, the ladies ask Olivia and Sophia to come back to the Squire's with them, which Dr. Primrose curtly refuses.

The Primroses feel their desire to be accepted by society all the more sharply in the presence of the town ladies, who make them feel ridiculous and provincial. Even Dr. Primrose is not immune to this; though he is offput by the town ladies' behavior, through a combination of moral generosity and personal insecurity he chalks this up to his own ignorance of high-class life. He is willing to give such members of the upper class the benefit of the doubt, in part because he seems their life and his family's as irreconcilably different. Nevertheless, Dr. Primrose is not so ignorant as to miss the Squire's innuendo, which greatly offends him, leading to his refusal to send his daughters to Thornhill castle.



CHAPTER 10

Dr. Primrose finds his family less and less receptive to his lectures on virtue, and Mrs. Primrose, Olivia, and Sophia begin to worry about their appearance again, making washes and taking care to protect their complexions. A fortune-teller comes to visit them, and in a moment of indulgence Dr. Primrose gives his daughters money to pay her. To their surprise, the fortune-teller predicts that Olivia will be married to the Squire in less than a year and that Sophia will marry a lord soon after. Dr. Primrose laughs it off, but soon notices the expectation of great things his family begin to hold. He reflects on the way that looking forward to something often gives greater pleasure than the thing itself, describing the happiness and sense of destiny his daughters feel.

The family receive a card from the town ladies, who hope to see them at church on Sunday. Dr. Primrose notices his wife and daughters planning something; Mrs. Primrose then suggests to him that the family ought to go to church in their Sunday best and that Olivia and Sophia should ride their two plow horses, Colt and Blackberry. Dr. Primrose does not see how this is more elegant, as Colt is wall-eyed and Blackberry has no tail, but Mrs. Primrose insists. On Sunday, Dr. Primrose goes ahead alone. His family fail to appear before or even during the service, and only walking back does he find them on the horses, which refused to move all morning. Despite his family's embarrassment Dr. Primrose is pleased, seeing the incident as a useful lesson in humility.

Dr. Primrose's struggles to rein in his family's expectations reveal just how strong the pull of jealousy is. This leads the family to plan elaborate schemes that would never have crossed their minds in Wakefield, where they were both comfortable and not in direct proximity to the very wealthy. Addressing this problem is far from simple, however, not only because the family is tiring of his lectures: as much as Dr. Primrose opposes their grandiose dreaming, he understands the happiness that such a vision for the future gives them, and happiness is ultimately exactly what he wishes his family to have.



Now goaded by the town ladies, Mrs. Primrose truly oversteps the bounds of her social position, not realizing how ridiculous this makes her look. The Primroses' horses are farm animals, not fit to ride; one of them is even wall-eyed, meaning his eyes look in different directions. Despite her husband's warnings, Mrs. Primrose's desire to appear distinguished blinds her to the embarrassment she is causing herself and her family. Dr. Primrose, ever the benevolent father, realizes here that he cannot lecture his family into submission but must allow them to make mistakes for themselves; luckily for him, the failure of their plan humbles them without the public humiliation that it might have led to.



CHAPTER 11

The Primroses go over to Flamborough's to celebrate Michaelmas, an invitation they might not have accepted before their most recent embarrassment, considering themselves above the Flamborough family. The party is nevertheless very pleasant, and Mr. Burchell organizes games for the children. In the midst of a game of hunt the slipper, the town ladies Blarney and Miss Carolina Wilhelmina Amelia Skeggs enter. The Primroses are embarrassed to be caught indulging in such activities in front of such cultured women, who were worried when Olivia and Sophia failed to appear in church. The ladies assure the Primrose daughters of their desire to be closer friends, and they continue to impress them with talk of aristocratic life. Throughout their conversation, however, Burchell rudely interrupts, shouting "Fudge!" after each of them speaks, much to Dr. Primrose's annoyance.

Michaelmas is a Christian festival celebrated on September 29. In their hesitation to spend time with the Flamboroughs, the Primroses reveal the uglier side of their newfound ambition, forsaking the company of the simple country folk who are not only their neighbors but, as parishioners, Dr. Primrose's livelihood, in order to appease the aristocrats. Once they arrive at the party, however, they realize how wrong they were to doubt Flamborough; Burchell's presence too shows how genuine a social space the peasant household is compared to the Squire's banquets. The arrival of town ladies, however, throws the family back into their aspirations—and, consequently, their embarrassment. Starry-eyed before such distinguished noblewomen, they are unable to make sense of Burchell's rude behavior, not even attempting to explain it to themselves.



Despite Burchell's interruptions, it becomes clear that the town ladies are each seeking companions, or educated servants who can both do needlework for them and entertain them. Mrs. Primrose deferentially suggests her daughters, with Dr. Primrose's tacit support, though once again Burchell cries out "Fudge!" as Mrs. Primrose lists their qualifications and qualities. The town ladies agree, but say that they would need further recommendations, and will turn to Squire Thornhill for his opinion.

The town ladies' suggestion of work is hardly the most subtle, but it is more than enough to convince Mrs. Primrose, who is hearing exactly what she wants to hear. Dr. Primrose, struggling to convince her otherwise, gives in entirely, and she offers Olivia and Sophia as applicants without a second thought in order to get them closer to wealthy potential husbands.



CHAPTER 12

The Primrose family returns home, and Mrs. Primrose envisions her daughters' future successes, feeling assured of Squire Thornhill's recommendation. Dr. Primrose is less optimistic, cautioning his wife's optimism. Mrs. Primrose then reveals her next scheme: to sell Colt and buy a riding horse. Dr. Primrose is strongly opposed at first but ultimately gives in, and the next day he sends Moses to make the sale, as Dr. Primrose has a cold, and he feels fully confident in his son's business sense. Dressed in his finest clothes, Moses leaves for the fair. The family then receives a message that the Squire has given Olivia and Sophia his recommendation; Mrs. Primrose is overjoyed.

Though Dr. Primrose lacks the emotional fortitude or convincing arguments to oppose his wife's plan, he still tries to temper her enthusiasm, albeit without success. The family's unshakeable faith in Moses's business acumen foreshadows an unfortunate conclusion to the horse-sale; the reader will recall the Dr. Primrose, when describing Moses as destined for business, said in practically the same breath that Moses was but young and had seen very little of the world. Indeed, it is unclear if Moses has every successfully closed a deal before. In light of the Squire's recommendation, however, he dismisses all doubt.



Mr. Burchell visits the Primroses; he's come from the fair and arrives with trinkets for the children. The Primroses ask Burchell for his advice regarding the town ladies, but his unenthusiastic response suggesting caution displeases them. Mrs. Primrose becomes rude and irate, and Dr. Primrose quickly changes the subject, wondering aloud what is keeping Moses at the fair. As Mrs. Primrose reaffirms her faith that Moses will make a successful trade, he returns without any horse or money, having spent the profits on a case of silver spectacles. Dr. Primrose quickly realizes that the spectacles are only copper, that Moses, along with Flamborough, has been cheated by two men who tricked him into making the purchase.

Despite Mr. Burchell's generosity and the good rapport he enjoys with Dick and Bill, his failure to gratify Mrs. Primrose is enough to set her against him, as she has become solely focused on her scheme. Dr. Primrose, still annoyed at Burchell for reasons he is unable or unwilling to fully admit to himself, struggles to play the role of mediator. Moses's having successfully been cheated overshadows all of these conflicts, however, with the overpowering sense of disaster preventing the family from critically examining the excessive confidence that led them to this point. Moses's failure, moreover, can be attributed not only to his gullibility, but also to his attempt to enter the speculative market and turn a profit by resale. Though such business offers great rewards, it also bears risks that simple trading does not.



CHAPTER 13

Reflecting on his family's recent embarrassments, Dr. Primrose lectures them on the folly of their attempts to rise above their station in life. Dick then illustrates this moral with a fable, telling the family the story of a giant and a dwarf who fought many battles together in which the giant got all the glory, and the dwarf lost limbs and eyes. Dr. Primrose's explanation is interrupted, however, by Mrs. Primrose's argument with Mr. Burchell, who is attempting to dissuade her from sending Olivia and Sophia to town. Mrs. Primrose accuses Burchell of being motivated by his own desire for Sophia. Seeing that his presence is now unwanted, Burchell departs in a hurry. Dr. Primrose scolds his wife for treating their guest so rudely but is secretly pleased that a poor man like Burchell will no longer be seeking—and receiving—his daughter's affections.

Dr. Primrose again attempts to impress on his family the futility of social climbing, and again they fail to heed his warning. Mrs. Primrose, suffering from tunnel vision regarding her daughters' future employment with the town ladies and the marital success that will surely follow, is unable to consider the dangers, and she angrily reacts to Mr. Burchell's suggestion of caution. While Dr. Primrose's condemnation of his wife for her lack of hospitality is morally straightforward, he must grapple internally with his own satisfaction with Burchell's departure, as he realizes that he too is not immune to the desire for greater things that has captivated his family.



CHAPTER 14

The Primroses prepare to send their daughters to town, where the Squire has promised to look after them personally. In need of money for their journey, the family decides that Dr. Primrose should sell their other horse, Blackberry. Dr. Primrose, while unexperienced in business, is confident of his success, though Mrs. Primrose warns him to be careful. At the fair he struggles to find someone willing to buy a one-eyed horse and grows increasingly embarrassed as potential bidder point out various defects. An old colleague arrives just then and suggests getting a drink together at the nearest tavern, saving Dr. Primrose from the spectacle.

Dr. Primrose, no longer trusting Moses to handle the family's business, resolves to sell Blackberry himself, failing to realize that he is likely a worse businessman than his son. The marketplace soon tests his humility; without realizing it, he takes the first price he is offered, retreating to the comfortable space of discussing theology with a colleague rather than facing the challenge he has taken on.



Entering the tavern, Dr. Primrose is entranced by an old, distinguished-looking man reading a book. As he and his colleague discuss religious controversy and Primrose's latest pamphlet, which the Church did not receive well, they witness the old man give a beggar child five pounds. Dr. Primrose's colleague then leaves, saying his name aloud in his goodbye, which the old man hears and asks if he is the same Primrose writing those brave monogamist tracts. Dr. Primrose is extremely flattered and continues to enjoy the old man's compliments—though he's puzzled when the man starts making obscure and contradictory pronouncements on cosmology. Turning to the subject of the fair, Dr. Primrose and the old man are pleasantly surprised to find that while Primrose is selling a horse, the old man is looking to buy one.

Once again, Dr. Primrose falls victim to a combination of naiveté and pride. While his attraction to generous people has not steered him wrong thus far, the speed with which he lowers his guard after the distinguished-looking man praises his theological tracts is astounding, presenting a sharp contrast to the prudence he preaches to his family. Even the old man's bizarre cosmological rambling—which Dr. Primrose recognizes as baseless—is not enough to reactivate his suspicions, as the man's compliments have thoroughly charmed him.



The old man sends his footman, Abraham, to get change to make the purchase, but he is unable to find change anywhere. The old man then asks Dr. Primrose if he knows Flamborough, an acquaintance of his and suggests a draught on Flamborough instead. Dr. Primrose agrees, and the old man, who is named Mr. Jenkinson, takes Blackberry and departs. Dr. Primrose soon has doubts, but Jenkinson is already gone, and so he goes at once to Flamborough's. There, to his dismay, Flamborough tells him that it was Jenkinson who cheated him and Moses at the fair before. Dr. Primrose prepares to tell his family but finds them already in distress, as the town ladies have left for London after hearing malicious, anonymous reports about Olivia and Sophia, the origin of which the Primroses cannot even guess.

Dr. Primrose, having lowered his guard, does not even think to question Jenkinson's excuse that he cannot get change, an utterly laughable claim at a country fair full of buyers and sellers. Any suspicion he may have left disappears when Jenkinson mentions the familiar name of Flamborough, and Dr. Primrose unwisely accepts a draught (a promissory note of debt) in Flamborough's name. Shortly afterward, as Jenkinson's personal charm wears off, Dr. Primrose begins to doubt his course of action, but it is too late; he has proven as ignorant of the world as his son, all the more so for his self-confidence. Another economic disaster for the family is small change, however, compared to the shattered dreams of Olivia and Sophia's move to London.

CHAPTER 15

As the Primroses continue to struggle to find out who is behind the slander against them, one of the boys finds a letter case outside. Opening it, they quickly realize it is Mr. Burchell's and that it contains a sealed copy of a letter to the town ladies. Unable to restrain themselves, they open it, finding a strange letter which, while dissuading the town ladies from hiring Olivia and Sophia, seems as much a criticism of the town ladies' virtue as the Primrose daughters'. Mrs. Primrose and Olivia are furious, while Sophia is in shock that Burchell could do such a thing. At that moment, they see Burchell approaching the house.

The Primroses resolve to confront Mr. Burchell, initially appearing as friendly as usual, cracking jokes with him and debating aesthetics. Dr. Primrose then confronts him directly, asking how he could write such a letter. Burchell asks how the Primroses could open a sealed letter, threatening legal action. At this Dr. Primrose becomes enraged and orders Burchell to leave and never return, which he does without any apparent guilt, upsetting Mrs. Primrose even more. To calm her, Dr. Primrose tells her an allegory about guilt, shame, and virtue explaining why the guilty often feel shame only for their good qualities, not their vices.

The Primroses, continually failing to practice humility and instead retreating into a cocoon of resentment, commit both an immoral act and a crime in opening Mr. Burchell's mail. While they do not entirely understand the cryptic letter, they immediately become defensive and vindictive, wallowing in their victimhood rather than giving Burchell the benefit of the doubt. Despite the degree to which this contradicts his morals, Dr. Primrose is too bewildered and demoralized to restrain his own emotions, let alone his family's.



The Primroses perpetuate their deceit by not confronting Mr. Burchell right away, seeking the maximum effect in their accusation rather than prioritizing honesty. Dr. Primrose's allegory, despite the lack of explanation on Burchell's part, affirms the family's self-satisfaction. Unlike many of the other stories he and his children tell to illustrate morality, this allegory of guilt and shame disregards both humility and redemption, instead giving those who believe themselves to be good an unearned sense of self-satisfaction and allowing them to reject those who are "guilty" without a second thought.



CHAPTER 16

While Sophia misses Mr. Burchell's company, the rest of the family find that Squire Thornhill's increasingly frequent visits make up for it. The Squire tries to entertain the Primrose daughters to make up for the disappointment of not going to London with the town ladies. Mrs. Primrose takes advantage of this to recommend Olivia to the Squire, always attributing the cooking, **gooseberry wine**, or other aspects of the home to her. Though Mrs. Primrose thinks she is being secretive, her ploys are obvious to everyone. However, the Squire is pleased nevertheless.

Sophia, motivated by her own personal affections, is the only member of the family to acknowledge that their break with Mr. Burchell does not entirely make sense. But the presence of Squire Thornhill, whose interest in Olivia becomes more and more evident, quickly overshadows any misgivings the family might have. The Primroses, however, may be seeing only what they want to see, reading flirtatiousness as serious courting. Mrs. Primrose's emphasis on Olivia's qualifications as a homemaker is doubly ridiculous, as it is not only completely transparent, but irrelevant—a Squire's wife has no need of cooking or cleaning skills, as she would have servants to do that for her.



Visiting Flamborough, Mrs. Primrose and her daughters find the Flamboroughs have had a limner paint their portrait, and they insist on having one done of their family, too. The Primroses insist on a more interesting style than that in which the limner painted the portrait of the Flamboroughs, and to fulfill their request the limner paints the Primroses as historical or mythical figures: Mrs. Primrose as Venus, Dick and Bill as Cupids, Dr. Primrose with his religious pamphlets, Olivia as an Amazon, Sophia as a shepherdess, and Moses in a hat with a white feather. The Squire insists on being included too, and the limner paints him as Alexander the Great at Olivia's feet, convincing the Primroses that he wants to marry Olivia and become part of the family.

Still jockeying for social position, the Primroses attempt to one-up the Flamboroughs to assure themselves that they are superior—in the process, however, they cause their biggest gaffe yet. The limner's portrait illustrates to what extent the Primroses are utterly without taste, as they commission a completely incoherent pastiche of characters. This kind of maximalism does not, as they believe, show distinction, but merely their embarrassing desperation to hold a higher social rank. Dr. Primrose, in encouraging his family, betrays his own aesthetic principles, which are opposed to classicism and mythical motifs in favor of pastoral simplicity.



While the Primroses are thrilled by the finished painting, they realize upon completion that it is too large to be hung in their house, forcing them to lean in against the kitchen wall much to their neighbors' amusement. Rumors begin to circulate about the Squire and Olivia, prompting Mrs. Primrose to test out a new scheme: asking the Squire's advice about another suitor for Olivia. Dr. Primrose only grudgingly accepts this plan with Olivia's promise that she will marry that suitor if the Squire does not propose to her, though he is still uneasy. When Mrs. Primrose suggests to the Squire that Olivia may marry farmer Williams, he strenuously opposes the match but refuses to make any commitment to her of his own, leaving the Primroses unsure what to think of his passion.

The Primroses' inability to physically hang the painting on their wall drives home and makes clear to the Primroses the obscene grandiosity of the family portrait. The portrait becomes a material example of the family's hopeless, misguided ambitions. Because the painting does, however, seem to nudge Olivia and the Squire's courtship a step further, Mrs. Primrose is emboldened not only to try her next scheme, but also to win her husband over to it. Dr. Primrose, equally guilty of seeing only what he wants to see, accepts this plan because he finds the possibility of a marriage between Olivia and farmer Williams redeeming, with part of him secretly hoping for that outcome instead.



CHAPTER 17

Dr. Primrose is pleased at the possibility of a marriage between Olivia and farmer Williams, whom he finds genuine and responsible, unlike the Squire. Nevertheless, the scheme continues without a clear answer from the Squire, leading Dr. Primrose to suspect he will not marry Olivia. Olivia holds out hope but agrees to her father's plan to set a date to marry Williams. This clearly upsets the Squire but does not induce him to action, confirming Dr. Primrose's suspicions. While his daughter's emotional distress upsets him, he thinks that the planned marriage will be a happier outcome in the end.

The likelihood of a marriage between Olivia and farmer Williams gratifies Dr. Primrose's morality, as such a match would be both a practical and responsible (if unambitious) decision, and it would also be a redeeming resolution to the disappointing courtship of the Squire. Though Olivia is not yet completely ready to accept this course of action, Dr. Primrose feels confident that she will not only keep her word but also come around to seeing the wisdom of it, finally proving right his lecture on the folly of attempting to rise above one's rank in life.



Gathered round **the fire**, the family discusses the future. Moses sees practical advantages in the marriage, as Williams will loan them farming equipment for free. Williams has also taught Dick and Bill songs, and as Dick has gone out with Olivia, Bill sings "An Elegy on the Death of a Mad Dog" for the family as his parents drink more **gooseberry wine**. Dr. Primrose interprets the song as a great tragedy and compares such old ballads to new—and, to him—inauthentic compositions. The family discusses the superior quality of English wives, which are considered the best in Europe, and as they drink one last bottle of gooseberry wine, Dr. Primrose expresses his contentment with his family and their future.

The family, after what has seemed to them to be a harrowing cycle of raised expectations and crushing disappointments, finally seems to be settling in for a future filled calm, peaceful normality. Planning future agricultural endeavors and enjoying their gooseberry wine, the Primroses feel a kinship with their neighbors, sharing a common land, culture, and morality. Thus, in Dr. Primrose's view, while they may not have reached the ambitious social position they hoped for, they have something better: a safe, stable kind of happiness.



As Dr. Primrose asks where Olivia has gone, Dick returns in a panic, telling the family that she has left with two gentlemen in a post chaise and that she clearly had romantic relations with one of them. The Primroses despair, and Dr. Primrose demands his pistols to go pursue Olivia's abductor, whom he curses. Mrs. Primrose dissuades him, however, and Moses encourages him to stay and support his family instead of selfishly pursuing revenge. Dr. Primrose calms down and realizes how rashly he was acting, recalling the importance of Christian forgiveness. Mrs. Primrose accuses Olivia of disgracing the family, claiming to disown her, though Dr. Primrose reminds her that they should always welcome back a repentant sinner. He then resolves to set out after Olivia, not with his pistols but with his Bible and staff, to bring her back to virtue.

The pastoral tranquility of both an evening by the fireplace and a long, steady future of more such evenings is shattered by the news of Olivia's abduction—or elopement—by post chaise, a kind of carriage. Dr. Primrose, in perhaps his most extreme slip of character in the entire novel, demands revenge, asking to be brought pistols he has likely never even used. Luckily his family dissuades him, presenting him with his own arguments, stressing his responsibility to the rest of his family over his sense of honor. Dr. Primrose quickly assents, thankful that his wife and son brought him back from the brink. He in turn must check the strength of their anger, however, reminding Mrs. Primrose that it is not their place as fellow sinners to judge Olivia. Instead, they must help her to find the way back to righteousness.



CHAPTER 18

Dick is unable to describe Olivia's abductor, but Dr. Primrose is convinced it is Squire Thornhill. On the way to the castle, however, a parishioner tells him that the abductor seemed to be Mr. Burchell. Still unsure, Dr. Primrose arrives at the castle, where he finds Squire Thornhill in shock too. Another witness, a friend of the Squire's, tips the balance in favor of Mr. Burchell being to blame, and so Dr. Primrose sets off for a well 30 miles away where Burchell and Olivia have been spotted, and then to the races 30 miles further. At the races he thinks he sees Burchell in the crowd but is unable to catch up to him. Dr. Primrose is preparing to return to his family when he falls sick and is forced to stop at a tavern to recover.

While his feelings got out of control moments before, Dr. Primrose is now perhaps excessively distrustful of his own intuition and is unsure what to make of the claims that it was Mr. Burchell who abducted Olivia; this accusation is hard to believe, given Burchell's affection for her sister Sophia, and his honorable conduct. Dr. Primrose does not suspect for a moment that friends of the Squire may be telling him things to mislead him; whether this is due to his distraught state or his trusting nature is unclear. Recalling his earlier excess of passion, Dr. Primrose eventually realizes that supporting the rest of his family must be his priority, as much as it pains him to give up his pursuit of Olivia.



Dr. Primrose runs out of money to pay his bill, but luckily a philanthropic bookseller who has published his tracts lends him some. Recovering his health, he heads home. On the way there, he meets a theater company wagon and starts up a lively conversation about contemporary drama with the actor driving it, and together they bemoan the current interest in Shakespeare and other Elizabethan dramatists. Arriving at the next village, they enter a tavern together, where a well-dressed gentleman asks if Dr. Primrose is a real chaplain or an actor. They then drink together as the gentleman eagerly discusses politics, and he insists Dr. Primrose and the actor should come to his home for dinner.

Dr. Primrose now finds himself the lucky beneficiary of cosmic justice, receiving the very same kind of help he once offered to Mr. Burchell, a seeming coincidence which vindicates his moral vision. His affable, unprejudiced nature leads him to spark up conversation with travelling actors, a class of people whom polite society (and certainly the religious establishment) generally looked down upon in 18th-century England. This is why the gentleman in the tavern asks Dr. Primrose if he's a real priest—the man finds it incongruous that an honorable vicar would socialize with actors.



CHAPTER 19

As the gentleman's carriage isn't ready, he, Dr. Primrose, and the actor walk to his house, a large and beautiful mansion. Some ladies arrive, and they sit down to eat; their host immediately starts to talk about politics. He asks Dr. Primrose if he has read the latest journals, affirming that he himself reads each and every one, and he praises liberty as Britain's highest value. The discussion then turns to the king, and his merits as a protector of that liberty. Dr. Primrose and the gentleman then begin a spirited debate; while Dr. Primrose advocates for the importance of the king's role in society, the gentleman argues that the king's power limits the liberty of individual citizens.

Forever trusting, Dr. Primrose does not consider the strangeness of a wealthy gentleman's carriage being indisposed, or how the gentleman got to the tavern if that was the case. Instead, he quickly becomes hostage to the gentleman's political rant. Goldsmith, parodying antimonarchists of the time, emphasizes the gentleman's pseudointellectualism with his impossibly broad reading. This comic encounter, however, soon becomes the vehicle for a genuine debate on the merits of monarchy.



To Dr. Primrose, natural inequalities in society require a leader like a king to temper them; a king should mediate between the wealthy and powerful and the “rabble,” who otherwise would crush the middle class who are the “true preserver of freedom.” In capitalist republics like Holland, Dr. Primrose sees the wealthy perpetrate even worse oppression against the poor. Dr. Primrose gets carried away in his speech and soon realizes he has offended his host, who accuses him of Jesuitism and tells him to leave. Dr. Primrose begs his pardon but is unable to placate him. At that moment, however, a footman tells them that the master of the house has come home; the “host” is only the butler, who chose to play the role of the master while his employer was away.

The true master of the house enters with, to Dr. Primrose’s surprise, Miss Arabella Wilmot, who is overjoyed to see him. The master is her uncle, Mr. Arnold. At Dr. Primrose’s urging the butler is not dismissed, and Mr. Arnold insists that Primrose stay with them for a few days. Walking in the garden with Dr. Primrose the next morning, Miss Wilmot asks if he has heard from George. He tells her he has not and catches her up on the sufferings of the Primrose family since the happier times they spent together around the **fireplace** at Wakefield; Miss Wilmot has not married since then and in fact has rejected several suitors since her engagement with George was broken off by her father, Mr. Wilmot.

At dinner, the manager of the theater company brings them tickets for a play that evening, “The Fair Penitent,” and praises the actor playing Horatio, who is completely inexperienced but very talented. The ladies convince Dr. Primrose to accompany them to the theater, and when the play begins, they realize the talented actor is George. When George sees his father and Miss Wilmot he freezes, bursts into tears, and leaves the stage. Mr. Arnold has George, who now refuses to act, brought to the house. Dr. Primrose observes how happy Miss Wilmot is in George’s company.

Dr. Primrose proposes a defense of monarchy which, like other political arguments in the novel, can be read as a stand-in for Goldsmith’s own opinion. In Dr. Primrose’s view, inequality is a natural if unfortunate aspect of society, and one that the government should seek to temper but not eradicate. While he is not entirely opposed to the emerging capitalist society of the 18th century, exemplified by the new middle class which he praises, he is suspicious of its ability to provide for the poor. To address this, the monarchy should serve as a mediator, tempering economic inequality, which becomes excessive in genuine republics. The gentleman’s furious response to this becomes quite comical when it turns out that he is merely a butler pretending to be a gentleman, suggesting that his resolute republicanism is not entirely distinguishable from his class resentment.



The shock of seeing Miss Wilmot provokes a twofold response in Dr. Primrose: he wonders what has become of George, and he considers what might have been if George and Miss Wilmot had successfully married. The close attention Miss Wilmot pays to him then raises the question of whether her relationship with George is truly over for good or if it can yet be redeemed.



The stunning reveal that George is the actor playing Horatio completes one cycle of redemption and begins another. The kindness and sociability Dr. Primrose showed to the actors pays off; had he dismissed them as socially beneath him, he may never have found his son again. George and Miss Wilmot’s happy reunion, on the other, seems to suggest that the Primrose family can repair the broken bonds between themselves and Wakefield.



CHAPTER 20

George, who does not have any possessions to his name, is asked by the company to tell his story. Arriving in London, he took Dr. Primrose's letter of recommendation to their cousin, who found George unfit to work at a school, describing the job as brutal and unrewarding. He suggested writing instead, pointing to the success of Grub-street hack writers. George's writing found no readers, however, and the literary establishment completely ignored it. Another author attempted to recruit George into a subscription scheme for his own hack journal, which George declined. He continued to write but was too focused on quality over quantity and therefore failed to gain any recognize for his publications. In despair, George was surprised to encounter his friend from university, Squire Thornhill. This surprises both Dr. Primrose and Mr. Arnold. Mr. Arnold admits that Thornhill, a good friend of his family, should be visiting them shortly.

George continues his story. Thornhill employed George as a retainer of sorts, dressing him up in fine clothes and bringing him to events, having him sing, and tasking him with various kinds of menial work around the house. George was not the only person employed in such a manner, and so he got caught up in an escalating contest of flattery, ending in George standing for Thornhill in a duel, which he won. To repay him, Thornhill recommended George to his uncle Sir William Thornhill. When George went to see Sir William, however, he firmly rejected the invitation and condemned George for enabling the Squire's bad behavior.

George began to lose hope and accepted an offer to go to America as an indentured servant. After signing but before departing, however, an acquaintance suggested he go to Holland instead and teach English, claiming that it was an easy and lucrative career. George left for Holland but found he could not teach English without learning Dutch himself; the Dutch also didn't embrace his ability to teach ancient Greek, not seeing any value in the language. George then wandered around to Paris, securing his lodgings by singing for peasants.

George's story, which draws heavily on Goldsmith's life experience, is both a miniature picaresque within the larger picaresque of the novel itself and an indictment of the injustice of 18th-century British society. George, an educated and honorable young man, is unable to find work at a school through no fault of his own but because the unfair, corrupted world of London is slanted in favor of haves and against have-nots. Despite the grandiose mythology of the free press and the arts, writing and publishing are no different, with the loudest voices crowding out those who actually have something to say. Hearing this shocks Dr. Primrose, revealing just how naïve he really is.



In an ironic turn of events, it is George who becomes a servant to the nobility, working for the Squire as his sisters were once slated to work for the town ladies. Disgraced and disheartened, George can only hope to leverage this service in the future, having lost faith that he will find success on his own merits in London. The Squire, in having his dependent George duel on his behalf (a common practice at the time), further demonstrates the economic inequality of their social relations. The failure of George's petitions, too, shows that while success without powerful friends is impossible, those friends seem to be far from dependable when one needs them most.



George gambles on a desperate shot at redemption, planning to quite literally start all over in the colonies. He is aware, however, that the opportunity will cost him—he will likely be worked to death before he makes something of himself. George's decision to go to Holland instead is a lucky break, but he finds that, tragically, his skills are just as unwanted there as they are at home.



In Paris George again met his cousin, who then brought him into the business of buying paintings for wealthy English gentlemen who in fact have very poor taste. George then worked as a tutor for a young and extremely stingy English aristocrat traveling through Europe, until his employer abandoned him in Italy in order to not pay for another ticket on the boat back to London. Unable to sing his way through Italy due to the country's own rich musical culture, George wandered his way back to England, surviving by debating at universities and thereby securing room and board. Back in England, he intended to go home to his family but met the theater company along the way and joined them on the road.

George's wealthy British interlocutors in Europe offer a withering parody of their real equivalents; at the time, it was common practice for young gentleman to "tour" Europe as part of their education, a journey often carried out in a rote manner with little genuine learning. Though George has learned much, the greatest lesson of his travels is the value of home, and so he sets off for England with a determination lacking in his earlier efforts.



CHAPTER 21

George's story is interrupted by the arrival of Squire Thornhill. The butler informs Dr. Primrose that the Squire is attempting to marry Miss Wilmot, with the Arnolds' approval. The Squire is clearly surprised to see the Primroses, but it's unclear if it's a pleasant or unpleasant surprise. The Squire asks Dr. Primrose about Olivia and says he has been comforting the Primrose family in his absence; he strongly approves of Dr. Primrose's decision not to tell George or Miss Wilmot just yet about Olivia's elopement. Later, Dr. Primrose observes that Miss Wilmot does not seem enamored with the Squire and is accepting his courtship to please her aunt and uncle; George, on the other hand, elicits tenderness and affection from her, prompting the Squire to seek his friendship more enthusiastically.

Fate rewards Dr. Primrose's graciousness in asking Mr. Arnold not to fire the butler, even though he was about to throw Dr. Primrose out of the house—now, the butler gives Dr. Primrose crucial information regarding the Squire's intentions. The meaning behind the Squire's inquiries about Olivia's is ambiguous; perhaps he is expressing genuine concern, or perhaps he is deflecting attention from himself. Regardless, a front of struggle seems to form between the Squire and the Primroses, as the Squire attempts to prevent George from threatening his engagement to Miss Wilmot.



Squire Thornhill generously procures an officer's commission for George to go the West Indies at the cost of 100 pounds, offering it as a loan as Dr. Primrose is unable to pay. George departs with his father's blessing, and Dr. Primrose leaves for him the next day. Stopping at an inn on the way, Dr. Primrose sits and talks with the owner, who harshly criticizes the Squire while praising his uncle, Sir William. The Squire, he claims, repeatedly seduces and abandons young women. They are interrupted by the innkeeper's wife complaining of a woman who will not—or cannot—pay for her room. To his shock, Dr. Primrose discovers the guest is his daughter Olivia.

The Squire's generous offer so surprises the downtrodden Dr. Primrose that he is unable to stop and consider whether it is a ploy to get George out of the way and ensure the Squire's unobstructed marriage to Miss Wilmot. Indeed, Dr. Primrose is so shocked that he does not even stop to consider the consequences of accepting such a large loan from the Squire. But the Squire's reputation among commoners like the innkeeper contrasts with his apparent good deeds. Once again, Dr. Primrose volunteers to help someone in need, knowing little of their circumstances. And once again he is rewarded for his generosity, discovering his daughter Olivia.



Olivia is in despair and does not believe her father when he says he forgives her. He asks her how Mr. Burchell could perpetrate such villainy, and Olivia corrects him: it was Squire Thornhill who seduced her, and in fact Burchell attempted to warn her beforehand. The town ladies were in fact prostitutes used as a ploy who were scared off by Burchell's letter. Thornhill, after kidnapping Olivia, had them illegitimately married by a Catholic priest; while this at first gives Dr. Primrose relief, Olivia explains that Thornhill has had six or more such marriages before.

Olivia was sworn to secrecy, however, and cannot inform on the priest, and though Dr. Primrose is aghast he supports her refusal to break an oath. The day after her "wedding," Olivia found the Squire would not be faithful to her alone and intended for her to engage in sex work for his benefit. She rejected this and his offers of money or marriage to someone else, instead running away and hiding in the inn ever since. Dr. Primrose plans to take her home and promises the family will forgive her too.

Olivia's despair, while tragic, indicates the depths of her moral feeling and therefore also her potential for redemption. The revelation that Squire Thornhill was indeed her abductor finally explains the town ladies' departure and Mr. Burchell's mysterious letter—and it exposes the Primroses' earlier actions as jealous and misguided. The revelation reveals Squire Thornhill to be even more villainous than Dr. Primrose suspected; dishonoring Olivia is immoral already, but false marriage is another degree of sin.



Dr. Primrose is gratified by Olivia's refusal to go back on her word, as much as it pains him to know that a fellow priest enabled such a crime against morality. Nevertheless, he firmly believes that evil—such as breaking an oath—cannot be done for the greater good. That Olivia also recognizes this affirms her fundamentally good nature and the redemption that awaits her, and her refusal to live in sin with the Squire after the initial seduction further indicates her goodness.



CHAPTER 22

On their way home Dr. Primrose reassures Olivia that Mrs. Primrose will also forgive her and praises the kindness of God. He decides to leave her at an inn nearby and return for her in the morning, heading home alone at night. As he arrives, however, he finds the house aflame and cries out before fainting. This wakes up Moses, who brings his mother and Sophia outside. Dr. Primrose wakes up and rushes in to save Dick and Bill, injuring his arm in the process.

Neighbors also come to help but it is too late to save the house; the Primroses spend the night in one of their outbuildings, and Dr. Primrose explains why he has been gone so long. Moses and Sophia go to fetch Olivia, and while her welcome is cold at first, Dr. Primrose insists on his wife's forgiving their daughter, telling her that a sinner's return to virtue is worth far more than the virtue of someone who has never sinned.

Dr. Primrose, firmly holding to his faith, thanks God for returning Olivia to him rather than cursing God for having taken her away. Attempting to lead by example, he encourages her to accept her mother's forgiveness, which he is confident will be forthcoming; the anger Mrs. Primrose felt is one based in love, and Dr. Primrose most firmly believes that love conquers all. His thanks to God strikes a darkly ironic note in light of the next disaster to strike the already beleaguered family as the house burns down. Unlike the end of George's engagement or Olivia's abduction, nobody can blame this tragedy on Dr. Primrose's pride or Squire Thornhill's villainy. Instead, it is an unlucky stroke of fate—or act of God.



The kindness and support the Primroses receive from their neighbors is all the more striking in light of the family's previous feelings of superiority to those neighbors; though they may look down upon the Flamboroughs and hope to marry lords, in the family's hour of need it is the Flamboroughs and not the lords who come to help them, an irony of fate that does not escape Dr. Primrose. Mrs. Primrose, while initially hesitant to accept Olivia back into the family, allows her husband to persuade her otherwise. Once more, Dr. Primrose stresses the central role of redemption in Christian morality.



CHAPTER 23

Neighbors continue to help the Primroses, and as Dr. Primrose cannot use his arm, he reads to his family to keep their spirits up. Olivia is particularly dejected and rejects farmer Williams's overtures, unable to recover her former innocence. To distract her Dr. Primrose tells the story of Matilda, an Italian woman who, after losing her child in a river, is abducted by French soldiers and marries one of their officers. She moves back to France with him and lives happily until the Italians besieged the city. After capturing it, they intend to execute her husband when the Italian general realized he is Matilda's lost son and spares her husband. The story does little for Olivia, however, who is further aggrieved by news of Squire Thornhill's engagement to Miss Wilmot. Moses is sent to inform Miss Wilmot of the Squire's treachery but is unable to deliver the letter as she is traveling. Dr. Primrose remains thankful for his family, no matter their circumstances.

Paradoxically, the suffering of the Primrose family is the surest proof of their fundamental goodness. Olivia's depression stems directly from her own moral nature and her inability to reconcile her dishonor with it. The story of Matilda, while it may appear to simply be a diverting tale encouraging the listener to never give up hope, foreshadows a later revelation regarding Mr. Burchell's true identity. The Primroses, though no longer seeking revenge, do hope to warn Miss Wilmot, not wanting a similar fate to befall her. Society, however—despite Dr. Primrose's faith in it—does not provide the downtrodden like the Primroses with the means to bring someone like Squire Thornhill to justice.



CHAPTER 24

The next day the Primroses have breakfast outdoors, though the surroundings only serve to remind Olivia of her misery. They spot Squire Thornhill's party in the distance, and the Primrose daughters return home. The Squire greets Dr. Primrose casually and familiarly when he arrives. This enrages Dr. Primrose, who then finally confronts him for his treachery. The Squire further upsets Dr. Primrose with his dismissive response, suggesting he can find another husband for Olivia and remain her lover regardless, prompting Dr. Primrose to call him a "reptile" and insist he leave. The Squire then threatens to press charges as Dr. Primrose has failed to pay back his debt to the Squire for George's commission, or his rent to the Squire's steward. He also invites the Primroses to his wedding, as Miss Wilmot has requested their attendance.

Squire Thornhill, unaware that Olivia has been found, attempts to keep up his ruse with the Primroses. Looking for a motive for him to take such a risk, the reader may recall not only the Squire's arrogance, but also the aim of his original plot with the town ladies: he still hopes to seduce Sophia, too. The Squire is not a moral man and struggles to understand how Dr. Primrose can be upset on principle, leading to his ill-advised suggestion that he can procure another husband for Olivia, which only adds insult to injury. The Squire's new threat to call in Dr. Primrose's debt offers two interpretations: it could suggest more of the same opportunism he's demonstrated thus far, or it could suggest that the commission for George was a ploy all along for leverage over the Primroses. Nevertheless, the Squire cannot afford for his fiancée, Miss Wilmot, to discover his treachery, and so he attempts to placate the Primroses for her sake.



Dr. Primrose tells the Squire that he will never consent to the Squire marrying anyone but Olivia and that the Squire can never again expect his friendship. The Squire tells Dr. Primrose he will face consequences for such insolence and leaves. While his family is worried, Dr. Primrose is unmoved. The next morning, however, the steward comes to demand the rent, seizing the Primroses' cattle as collateral. Though his family begs him to bow to the Squire's will to avoid prison, Dr. Primrose refuses. The next day, after a heavy snowfall, officers of justice come to take Dr. Primrose to the gaol on foot, despite his age and injuries. Nevertheless, he goes willingly, though his family, Olivia in particular, is in despair.

Dr. Primrose, despite his humility, now finally stands up to the Squire, not for his own sake but for Olivia's. Of course, the reader will note that in defending his daughter's honor, Dr. Primrose is also by proxy defending his own. The Squire, unwilling or unable to face them directly, sends his steward and the officers of justice in his place, further evidence that the structures of society are biased against the poor in favor of the rich. Though Dr. Primrose is aware of this, he does not see it as his place to challenge the justice system, and he goes willingly to the gaol.



CHAPTER 25

Dr. Primrose's family accompanies him on the journey, though Olivia is weakened by a fever. Soon an angry crowd of parishioners stops them, demanding Dr. Primrose's release and threatening to fight the officers of justice. Dr. Primrose angrily scolds them and sends them away, however, and they continue onwards. The family stops at an inn while Dr. Primrose is conducted to the prison. He is surprised by the merriment there as the prisoners drink and carouse, and he attempts to be cheerful himself, too.

Closely connected to Dr. Primrose's belief in a benevolent, moderating, and reformist constitutional monarchy, both in practice and in principle, is his abhorrence of violence and revolution. Thus, he confronts his parishioners with disgust, refusing to give them credit for their bravery or loyalty to him and instead castigating them for their unlawful, sinful behavior. Though Dr. Primrose firmly believes in the goodness of the law, this does not necessarily imply that those who break the law are evil, as his measured appreciation of his fellow prisoners suggests.



Talking to another prisoner, who offers Dr. Primrose some of his bedding to make his cell more comfortable, Dr. Primrose is surprised to recognize the prisoner's quotations about cosmogony. Realizing it is Mr. Jenkinson, Dr. Primrose confronts him but then forgives him and promises to send Moses to convince Flamborough not to testify so harshly against him. They resolve to be friends before they are sent to their cells for the night, where Dr. Primrose sleeps excellently.

Once more, Dr. Primrose's generosity is repaid in kind. And, once again, the source of his much-needed help is an unexpected old acquaintance: Jenkinson. Dr. Primrose forgives Jenkinson not only because Jenkinson's selfless act of assisting him, but also because he finds Jenkinson's remorse to be genuine. Though to Dr. Primrose such moral judgments are most relevant for heaven or hell, he too believes that remorse merits mercy on earth, which is why he promises to convince Flamborough that Jenkinson wants to make amends. Dr. Primrose sleeps very well in the prison because he is confident his actions are just and right.



CHAPTER 26

Dr. Primrose's family wakes him up. They've left Olivia at the inn, as she has gotten even sicker. Moses goes to find apartment closer by but can only rent a single room; the gaoler allows Moses, Dick, and Bill to sleep in their father's cell. Moses then goes to work to support the family. Dr. Primrose, exploring the prison, is determined to preach to his fellow inmates. They quickly accept this, but more out of a desire for entertainment than religion, and they mock Dr. Primrose throughout his service. Nevertheless, he affirms to them his desire to instill morals in them and warns them of the dangers of sin. Some prisoners praise this speech, and Dr. Primrose resolves to continue preaching the next day.

Many small redemptions occur throughout the prison sequences of the novel. Moses receives the chance to redeem himself as a worker, as he becomes the sole source of income for his family; the gaoler's kindness toward Dr. Primrose redeems the cruelty of the justice system is redeemed, at least in part; and, most importantly, Dr. Primrose's preaching, despite the skepticism of his family and friends, will redeem the prisoners.



Jenkinson eats dinner with the Primroses and is struck by Sophia's beauty. He also confesses to Moses that he swindled him for the spectacles and apologizes. Moses then asks him how Jenkinson picked him as a target and about his life as a con man. Jenkinson says that it was Moses's fine clothes that alerted him. He then bemoans his own cleverness, claiming that his cunning nature prevents him from honest hard work and its subsequent reward, comparing himself to Flamborough. He then asks Dr. Primrose why he is in prison, hoping he may be able to do something to help. After hearing the story, Jenkinson slaps his forehead and seems to come up with some kind of plan, telling Dr. Primrose he will see what he can do.

Jenkinson's revelations add depth to the cheating of Dr. Primrose, Moses, and Flamborough, suggesting that it was not only their unworldly simplicity that led them to become Jenkinson's targets—it was also their vanity and pride, in the form of clothing or intellectual conversation. Though Jenkinson may have been the smarter person in those encounters, ultimately, he sees more value in a humble existence than an unstable and unsustainable life of immorality and crime. Though Jenkinson seems to feel that it is too late for him to reform, in helping Dr. Primrose he intuitively grasps that he has received a chance at redemption.



CHAPTER 27

Dr. Primrose's family disapproves of his plan to reform the prisoners through preaching, but he goes ahead with it anyway, affirming that even the most wicked criminal still deserves a chance at redemption. He then goes into the common area and begins his sermon, though the prisoners play cruel pranks on him throughout. Dr. Primrose does not react to these provocations and after several days finds the prisoners much quieter and more attentive. Dr. Primrose thinks of secular ways to help them too, encouraging them to convert their hobby of cutting tobacco stoppers into a subscription-based cottage industry, which he manages. He also sets up a system of rewards and fines for moral and immoral behavior. Within two weeks, he finds the atmosphere in the prison noticeably improved.

This scene carries Dr. Primrose's belief in forgiveness to its logical conclusion. His family, which consists of otherwise moral individuals, tries to dissuade him. But Dr. Primrose stays firm as he understands that for his doctrine of redemption to hold true, it must hold true for everyone: if the criminal cannot be redeemed of their sins, nobody can. His patience and humility finds practical application here, as he endures the tricks the other prisoners play on him without reacting and soon finds success. Curiously, Dr. Primrose's program for moral education contains business as an integral part, complicating his largely antagonist relationship to the capitalist economy of 18th-century England.



Dr. Primrose reflects on his success and on the law more generally, finding that it should do far more to reward and rehabilitate criminals rather than exclusively punish them. He is especially opposed to capital punishment for any crime except murder, arguing that property alone is never a reason to take a life, and pointing out that in more "savage" societies very few crimes receive the death penalty. The problem, as he sees it, is that the law is made by the rich and applied to the poor. He bemoans Britain's comparatively high incarceration rate, and dreams of a system in which law protects rather than rules tyrannically over the people. To Dr. Primrose, such a system is not only possible but necessary, and it could both reduce violence in society and save the souls of criminals whom society too quickly dismisses as morally irredeemable.

Much like during the earlier debate with the butler, here Dr. Primrose serves once more as a mouthpiece for Goldsmith's own views of legal justice and prison reform. Arguing from an intellectual and moral foundation of Christian forgiveness, Dr. Primrose bemoans both the primacy of property in the law over human life and the legal system's lacking interest in reforming and reeducating criminals. In effect, he argues that the law perpetuates crime just as often as it prevents it. Thus, in his discourse on justice, Dr. Primrose is able to synthesize his moral-religious and practical inclinations, gesturing to how a more forgiving justice system would not only be more Christian but more effective, too.



CHAPTER 28

Olivia visits Dr. Primrose for the first time since his imprisonment and is noticeably unhappy and unhealthy looking. While he urges her to be happy and trust in a better future, she asks him to submit to Squire Thornhill's demands in the hope that he will show pity. Dr. Primrose refuses, saying he will never allow such an insult to her honor to stand. After Olivia leaves, Jenkinson presses her cause, asking Dr. Primrose if he thinks it is right to sacrifice his family's wellbeing for Olivia's honor or to obstruct the Squire and Miss Wilmot's marriage. Dr. Primrose again rebuffs these arguments, as he does not believe the Squire will be inclined to spare him and could not bring himself to approve of the Squire's adultery regardless. Jenkinson agrees but points out that Olivia is wasting away; he suggests Dr. Primrose petition Sir William Thornhill.

Dr. Primrose anxiously awaits an answer from Sir William, but none arrives, and he soon begins to lose hope. His health begins to decline; Olivia's declines even faster, however, and Jenkinson soon tells Dr. Primrose that she has died. Dick and Bill attempt to comfort their father, assuring him that Olivia is happier in heaven now. Jenkinson presses the case that Dr. Primrose should make peace with the Squire to protect the rest of the family. Dr. Primrose consents to this plan, feeling he has no pride left, and Jenkinson writes a letter on Dr. Primrose's behalf approving of the Squire's marriage to Miss Wilmot. Moses carries the letter to the Squire, who tells him that Dr. Primrose's submission comes too late; the Squire heard of the Primroses' petition to his uncle, who rejected it without a reply, and that any future letters should be sent to his attorney.

Just as Dr. Primrose has accepted his fate, Mrs. Primrose tells him that Sophia has been kidnapped by two well-dressed men in a post chaise. Neither of the men is Squire Thornhill. As Dr. Primrose despairs, Moses attempts to comfort him by showing him a letter from George, who is happy and successful in the army. A letter Mrs. Primrose sent to him must have luckily miscarried, as she asked him to seek revenge against the Squire. Dr. Primrose scolds her angrily but praises their luck. In the letter, George fondly reminisces about their **fireplace** at Wakefield and expresses sadness at not hearing from his family for some time.

Just as the Primroses rejoice, George is brought to the prison wounded and in fetters. He did receive his mother's letter after all and attempted to duel the Squire, who sent four servants to fight George instead, one of whom George severely wounded. George is clearly legally in the wrong and will be punished, perhaps even with the death penalty. To comfort his son, Dr. Primrose leads his family and the prisoners in prayer.

Dr. Primrose, attempting to defend his daughter's honor, now fails to live up to his own principles, refusing to humbly accept the Squire's marriage to Miss Wilmot, which he can only obstruct anyway, not prevent. Though Dr. Primrose may be right that the Squire will not forgive him if he submits, his refusal to make the attempt is based not on reasoning but on his sense of pride. The attempt to petition Sir William, despite his reputation for being just, seems doomed to failure given the failure of George's earlier petitions.



Olivia's death is the last straw for Dr. Primrose, who now has no reason to cling to his pride. It is unclear if his willingness to submit to the Squire comes too late, or if the Squire always intended to keep him imprisoned. The rejection of the family's petition to Sir William, too, leaves them utterly without hope.



While Dr. Primrose is capable of submitting to his own fate, the abduction of Sophia, too, is more of a disgrace than he can bear, as he is now truly powerless to help his family. The family takes comfort in George's letter—so much comfort that Dr. Primrose is able to forgive his wife's incredibly unwise decision to ask George to duel the Squire—the most affecting aspect of which is not George's career achievements, but the simple pleasures of familial love he still professes.



George, chained around the ankles, is now guilty for the second time of dueling. Though the Squire's decision to send four surrogates is hardly honorable, as the aggressor George is at fault, especially as he wounded one of the men. All that is left now for Dr. Primrose is his faith, hence his turn to prayer.



CHAPTER 29

In Dr. Primrose's sermon, he reflects on suffering and hope in the world and why suffering is necessary. He deems attempts to answer this question through philosophy insufficient and often contradictory, either focusing on the pleasures or miseries of life. Religion, by contrast, explains suffering as mental preparation for the word to come. Whether one is happy or unhappy, religion gives them something to look forward to. Religion gives particular comfort, Dr. Primrose argues, to those who suffer most. Dr. Primrose sees the happiness of heaven after a hard life on earth as proof that religion is a greater advantage to the poor than the rich, balancing out the rich's greater enjoyment of worldly pleasures. Looking around at the prison's dismal surroundings, he encourages all the prisoners to look forward to death and prepare themselves for the happier life to come.

In his speech, Dr. Primrose addresses a number of philosophical arguments about the meaning of life and the necessity of suffering, rebutting them in favor of a religious explanation. Through this moving speech, Goldsmith clarifies for the reader just what the moral goodness of such an utterly unworldly man such as Dr. Primrose consists of. Dr. Primrose, holding fast to a religious notion of goodness that does not exist in the corrupt world, is willing to suffer all manner of humiliations, knowing that it is for the afterlife that his conduct matters. This is not only a personal philosophy, however, but also an answering to the suffering of all the downtrodden.



CHAPTER 30

The sermon concludes, and George is moved to his own cell. However, the gaoler says they will allow him to visit Dr. Primrose every day. Jenkinson then tells Dr. Primrose he has heard news of Sophia, who was seen with a stranger on the way back to town. Suddenly Sophia enters, together with Mr. Burchell. The Primroses thank Burchell and apologize for the way they treated him, which he does not hold against them. Sophia explains the story of her escape: the still unknown gentlemen took her into their post chaise, but she saw Burchell walking nearby and cried out for help; he then successfully fought off her kidnappers, but they were able to escape on foot. Dr. Primrose praises Burchell's heroism and offers Sophia's hand in marriage to him, despite Burchell's poverty. Burchell does not answer, however, and instead orders food and wine from the nearest inn.

The gaoler's continued kindness to Dr. Primrose affirms that the justice system is reformable and that dispensing justice with kindness is a very real possibility. The arrival of Sophia with Mr. Burchell, however, upends Dr. Primrose's despair and acceptance. Now it is the Primroses' turn to ask for forgiveness, which Mr. Burchell grants them as readily as Dr. Primrose has to others. Having learned his lesson from the family's disastrous attempts to position their daughters to "marry well," Dr. Primrose resolves not to let slip the opportunity to offer Sophia to Mr. Burchell, an honorable, righteous man.



Though he does not want to dampen her spirits, Dr. Primrose tells Sophia what has happened to George. George enters the room and stares at Mr. Burchell in wonder. Burchell turns to George and chastises him for once again committing "the same crime," but is interrupted by the gaoler telling Burchell that a distinguished person has arrived and wishes to see him; Burchell tells him to wait. Burchell then continues to scold George for dueling, until Dr. Primrose explains that George did so on Mrs. Primrose's behalf, showing him the letter. Burchell concedes that this is at least a partial excuse, and he forgives him. He then reveals that he has come to seek justice for Dr. Primrose—and he is in fact none other than Sir William Thornhill.

In confronting George, Mr. Burchell finally reveals himself to be Sir William. Here he once again shows himself to be a kindred spirit to Dr. Primrose on the matter of justice, tempering his anger at George for committing the crime of dueling when he learns of George's motivations, which explain if not justify his actions.



The Primroses are astounded, but Sir William returns to the subject of Sophia's kidnapper. She describes the man as a long-legged redhead; Jenkinson recognizes him as Timothy Baxter and moreover knows where he is hiding. At Sir William's request, the gaoler allows Jenkinson and two officers to go after Baxter. Sir William then plays with Dick and Bill and dines with the Primroses; later, he prepares a treatment for Dr. Primrose's arm. The party then receives news that Squire Thornhill has arrived.

CHAPTER 31

Sir William rejects his nephew's familiar greeting, sternly expressing his disapproval at the way Squire Thornhill has treated the Primroses. He concedes, however, that the Squire was right not to duel George, and he seems convinced by the Squire's claims that there were only rumors about his tryst with Olivia and by his claim that his steward carried out Dr. Primrose's imprisonment harshly but entirely legally. The Squire points out the Primrose's inability to contradict his story and his intention to press full charges against George. Mrs. Primrose begs Sir William to help them, but he seems inclined to believe his nephew. Suddenly Jenkinson enters with Baxter as a prisoner, which seems to frighten the Squire.

Jenkinson asks the Squire if he is ashamed of his "two old acquaintances," himself and Baxter, and explains that Baxter has confessed to both dueling George—and claiming, falsely, to be wounded—and kidnapping Sophia, both on the Squire's behalf. The Squire then planned to appear to rescue Sophia in order to seduce her. Sir William is aghast, but he notes that there is not sufficient evidence to arrest the Squire. The Squire's butler is brought in, and he confirms the Squire's history with Baxter, who procured women for him. The butler also reveals that Jenkinson brought the priest who illegitimately married Olivia and the Squire, and Jenkinson confesses. Sir William asks the gaoler to free George at once, and then he requests Olivia's testimony.

Jenkinson continues to redeem himself, using his own underworld past to offer the Primroses a chance at capturing Sophia's abductor that they never would have had otherwise. Had Jenkinson always been good, there would have been no such opportunity to capture Baxter, echoing Dr. Primrose's earlier assertions that a redemptive sinner is worth far more than a perfectly righteous individual.



The Squire, confronted at last, presents a sharp contrast to the Primroses in the arrogance, elaborate deflections, and excuses with which he responds to his uncle's accusations. Whether through luck or careful plotting—or the simple benefits of wealth—the Squire does indeed have the law on his side, driving home Dr. Primrose's earlier reflections on the unfortunate divergence of the law and justice. As on previous occasions, the arrival of an unexpected person (now Baxter) throws the Squire off balance and betrays the true feelings beneath his collected appearance.



Whereas the help Dr. Primrose willingly offers to others with no chance of personal gain has now returned to him several times, the Squire's cruelty and selfishness leads his former servants to desert him one after the other as they learn of his crimes. Sir William has George freed because he realizes that following the letter of the law in this case would not be to do justice, given the elaborate machinations of his nephew that led George to commit his crime.



Dr. Primrose is about to explain that Olivia has died when Miss Wilmot enters—she had been on her way to the wedding when she learned about Dr. Primrose’s imprisonment and stopped to visit him. Dr. Primrose muses on the chain of coincidences that led to her arrival, but also the coincidences that take place constantly in everyday life. Miss Wilmot compliments the Squire on what she thinks is also a charitable visit, but then Sir William explains the truth. Miss Wilmot then reveals that the Squire told her George had married and left for America; at this, Mrs. Primrose tells her that George will never love another woman but her. George enters, no longer in fetters, and Miss Wilmot confesses her love for him too. Moses quickly goes to inform Mr. Wilmot of the situation and bring him to the prison

Miss Wilmot, unaware of what has happened, comes to the prison only to see Dr. Primrose, with whom she deeply sympathizes, proving her fundamental goodness. Her reaction to the revelations of what her fiancée has done likewise attests to her character. In professing her love for George, she opens up the possibility that the Primroses and the Wilmots can redeem the first great mistake of the novel through the power of love. Dr. Primrose’s reflections on coincidence further emphasize the role of fate in the novel, as both incomprehensible to human reason and something that must be trusted as expressing the will of God.



The Squire, however, has already taken possession of Miss Wilmot’s fortune as part of the engagement. Nevertheless, Miss Wilmot says she would rather lose her fortune and marry George, and he happily agrees. Mr. Wilmot, however, is dismayed by the loss of his fortune, and Sir William scolds him for his greed and encourages him to acceptance George as her husband. Mr. Wilmot agrees, asking only that if Dr. Primrose ever recovers his fortune he pay a 6,000-pound dowry, which Dr. Primrose accepts. Jenkinson arrives just then and asks how the fortune can be the Squire’s if the Squire is already married. The Squire replies that he has never *legally* married another woman. Jenkinson leaves, promising to be back in a moment.

The Squire’s seizure of the Wilmot fortune provides yet another example of someone manipulating the law for unjust ends. In accepting the loss of her fortune, however, Miss Wilmot demonstrates the same kind of humility that Dr. Primrose has striven to embody, a testament to her character. Sir William’s scolding of Mr. Wilmot isn’t intended to punish him—it’s meant to offer him a chance of redemption by following his daughter’s example and letting go of his greed. Jenkinson’s cryptic pronouncement suggests that the law is not entirely the Squire’s to manipulate, however.



Jenkinson returns with Olivia, who is actually still alive. He also has the license for her marriage to the Squire, which is in fact legitimate; Jenkinson, seeking future blackmail against the Squire, secretly brought him a real priest to perform their marriage. Olivia is restored to honor, and everyone rejoices. Jenkinson explains to Dr. Primrose that he convinced the family to tell Dr. Primrose that Olivia was dead, hoping it would convince him to submit to the Squire and hopefully secure his release from prison, and there had not yet been an opportunity to reveal the scheme. The Squire then begs his uncle for forgiveness, which Sir William is not inclined to grant him until Dr. Primrose asks him to; Sir William then agrees to give his nephew a small allowance, and the fortune will instead go to Olivia, his wife.

Jenkinson’s revelation not only redeems Olivia’s honor but his own, turning what was an immoral act of blackmail into an act of heroism, saving the day for both the Primroses and the Wilmots. The Squire’s attempt to beg for forgiveness is clearly not genuine, coming only when he has no other options. Still, Primrose convinces Sir William to offer the Squire forgiveness in order to counter the Squire’s immorality with kind, moral justice with an eye toward reforming the Squire.



Everyone congratulates Olivia, and only Sophia seems unhappy. Sir William suggests that, as a reward, Jenkinson should marry Sophia. Sophia refuses this proposal, and so Sir William decides that he will marry her himself, revealing that his suggestion was merely another ruse. To Jenkinson, however, he will provide a small fortune of 500 pounds. Dr. Primrose is released, and Sir William and Mr. Wilmot distribute money amongst the prisoners, too. After a celebratory dinner, Dr. Primrose wants to be alone, leaving the company to pray for the joy and the sorrow he has experienced, and sleeps soundly once again.

Sir William's suggestion that Sophia marry Jenkinson, while jarring and unexpected, is quickly revealed to be another of his tricks—and perhaps another test of Sophia's love for him. The reward Sir William gives to Jenkinson proves the value one may find in giving up a life of crime and redeeming oneself, and ideally the donations the other prisoners receive will encourage them to do the same. Dr. Primrose, having thanked God for his family's deliverance, sleeps soundly once again—something he has been able to do throughout the novel's tumultuous events precisely because he never abandoned his principles.



CHAPTER 32

The next morning George wakes up Dr. Primrose to tell him that the merchant who stole their family fortune was arrested in Antwerp, with enough money to compensate the creditors he defrauded. Sir William then enters and tells Dr. Primrose he has procured marriage licenses and asks him to officiate the marriages. The light-hearted atmosphere amongst the company frustrates Dr. Primrose, who sees marriage as a ceremony to be taken seriously. Eventually, however, the marriages are performed, first Sir William and Sophia, and then George and Miss Wilmot. Flamborough and his family attend the party afterward, and his daughters pair off with Jenkinson and Moses. The parishioners who attempted to free Dr. Primrose come too, and when Sir William is told the story he also harshly rebukes them, but then gives them all money to drink and celebrate too.

The cycle of redemption comes full circle: George and Miss Wilmot are married, and the Primrose family gets their fortune back. In officiating the marriages of his son and daughter, Dr. Primrose closes this chapter of his life. And the novel hints at happy futures for Moses and Jenkinson. Even Dr. Primrose's rebellious parishioners are both forgiven and invited to celebrate. For the Primrose family, the wedding is not only closure, but a reunion with their community after many trials and tribulations.



Squire Thornhill moves to a relative's home, where he practices playing the French horn. Olivia holds out hope that he may reform himself, at which point she would allow him to live with her. Back at the wedding party, the whole group sits down to eat and celebrate, joking and laughing throughout. Afterward, Dr. Primrose requests that they once again all sit by **the fireplace**, and he reflects on his happiness; the task now, he tells himself, is to ensure that he is as grateful for his good fortune as he was patient with his previous sufferings.

The Squire, despite all his villainy, is forgiven for his past iniquities, and both Olivia and Dr. Primrose hold out hope that he too will redeem himself. Ultimately, however, the Primroses cannot be responsible for the Squire's moral choices and must return to their own simple way of life. In their travels, they have seen and experienced many things, and Dr. Primrose hopes they will heed the lessons their hardships have taught them and continue to live with gratitude, humility, and moral generosity.





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